

General Montessori Theory

Four Planes of Development

Lecture on October 31, 2022 by Jenny Höglund

Maria spent her learning by observation. From observing she laid out different stages of development. The 4 stages of growth she dubbed, The Four Planes. There are four planes and four separate learning approaches for each age. These are the four planes of education. Maria Montessori said, “education should aid life.” No matter where a child is at, we can always meet them and begin to guide them

Young children are presented with chemistry and geometry. The young child starts with concrete and sensorial materials before they have the ability to think abstractly. Montessorians are in the service of human development not of future professions. Maria Montessori had a holistic view of the human. She believed that the human should be nurtured socially, morally, physically, intellectually, emotionally, and spiritually. Development is all about nature and it has a schedule.

Education is to help develop life, but it has to be different for each individual. It is not a recipe. The learning for each child must be individualized. Academic work comes later and is often a by-product of this style of learning. Education should allow the child to develop naturally.

All children have potentialities and in a prepared environment each child should find what is necessary for their development.

There is particular help that must be given at each plane. You must first know the child and the corresponding plane. Children have their own unique contributions in each plane. In the third plane, we know that the child has come from 12 years of construction work.

- ❖ First Plane: (0-6) “Early Childhood”
- ❖ Second Plane: (6-12) “Plane of Childhood”
- ❖ Third Plane: (12-18) “Plane of Adolescence
- ❖ Fourth Plane: (18-24) “Plane of Adulthood”

Each of these above planes is a new birth. Maria Montessori compares it to that of an insect’s metamorphosis.

Similarities between Early Childhood (0-6) and Adolescent Planes (12-18)

- a. Both planes have sudden and dramatic changes.
- b. Physical Transformations
- c. Instable periods and likelihood of illness
- d. Rapid changes in emotions and feelings
- e. Group bonding
- f. The young child bonding with their family group is very important
- g. Young children have societies of cohesion
- h. Social community is important for the adolescent
- i. The physical environment is very important to both

Maria Montessori named the 0-6 plane children the **möbelkinder**, meaning, “furniture children,” because their development was very heavily weighed on by the furniture and access to material items in the casa environment.

Absorbent Mind: The absorbent mind describes the child during the first plane of development from birth to 6 years old. They soak in everything about the environment around them. This includes the traditions, language, and the social environment. They do this through observation. The child is like a camera. They soak in the environment around them. This includes the traditions, language, and the social environment. With learning language, you must have eye contact and it must have a human connection. From years 0-3, children have the most optimal

opportunity to learn a language. From 3-6, children can refine their techniques. This is considered a sensitive period. They are periods of powerful learning capabilities. They are able to learn a lot and retain the information to aid in their future development.

She named the 12-18 plane adolescents, **Erdkinder**, meaning, “land children,” because it was very important for them to be in touch with the land and interconnected with the surrounding society.

Second and Fourth Planes

These planes are periods of stability and no drastic planes. They are very strong and robust. They don't get sick like they did when they were in the first or third plane. Second plane is sometimes called the, “age of rudeness,” because they are very honest. They openly speak about their observations but they are not judgmental. They just speak the truth!

All Planes

All planes are about becoming and belonging. Nature provides tools for each of these planes, to guide the humans. Human tendencies come into play, as do sensitivities and sensitive periods.

3 Threats to Children

1. Dress: Children want to do things themselves during early childhood. The adults around them must leave ample time for them to be able to complete tasks on their own.
2. Transport: Allow them to walk if they can! Leave time for travel. They can walk at the grocery store and it's ok to touch things. That is how they are learning.
3. Technology: Never allow the young child to be in front of a screen before two years old.
4. Trends: (Mostly for the adolescent)

General Information about the Four Planes of Development:

It is important to remember that human development is not linear. These 4 planes of development represent 4 different transformation periods in a human's life. The transformations can be so gradual that it is hard for parents to realize this about their children. The second plane provides a

tremendous opportunity for learning. From 1 to 2 years old, the child learns an incredible amount. A child leaving an elementary montessori school is two years ahead of a child leaving a traditional elementary school. It actually feels more crucial that the youngest child is in school consistently during young childhood from 0-3 years old especially. Limited vacations is a good idea. Some people in current culture think that they can travel and be gone for long periods of time with the youngest child but practical life and community is so important to their development during this sensitive period. Adolescents can almost go on vacation at any time because they will still be able to do their most important work on vacation.

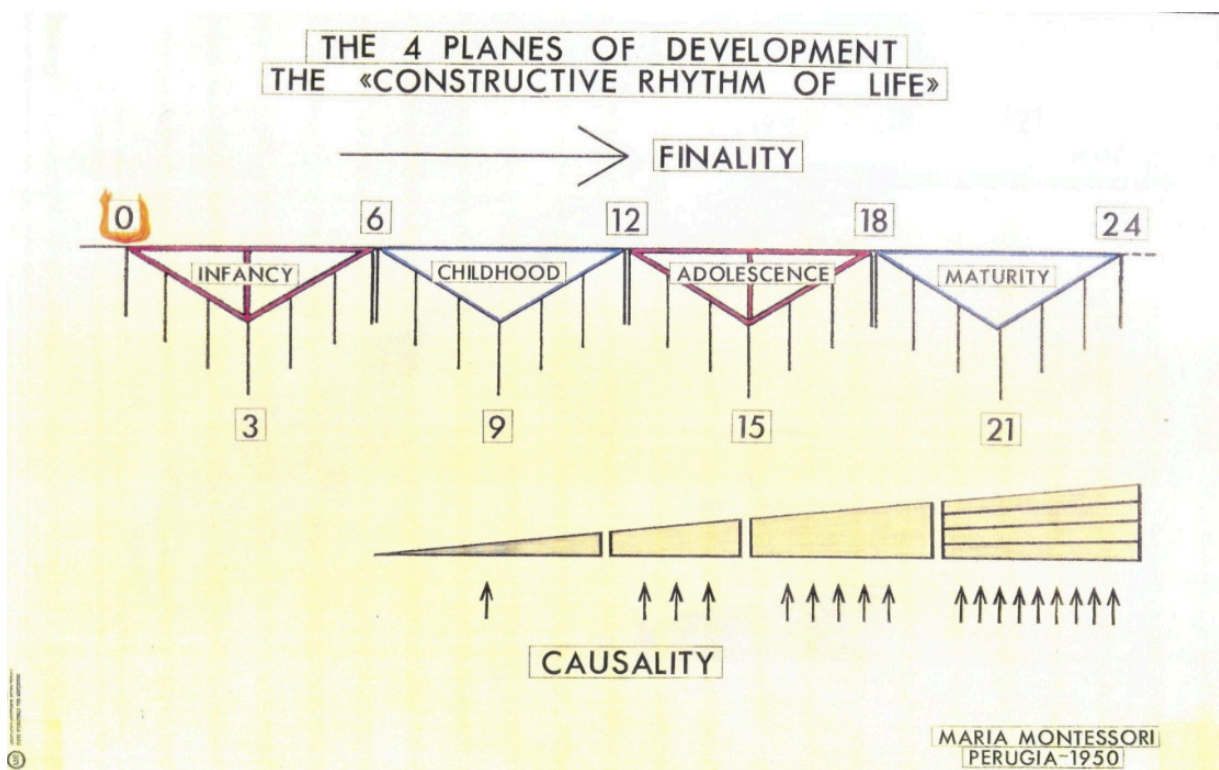
Maria read and studied other pedagogs. It was a new and progressive way of thinking about education. She was not alone in this education reform.

- a. Erik Erickson- former student of Mario
- b. Jean Piaget
- c. Sigmund's Daughter Anna Freud
- d. Paulo Freire (Brazilian) Pedagogy for the oppressed.
- e. Lawrence Kohlberg: Stages of Development
- f. Fowler: Spiritual development

The Charts

Lecture November 1, 2022 by Jenny Höglund

Chart 1:



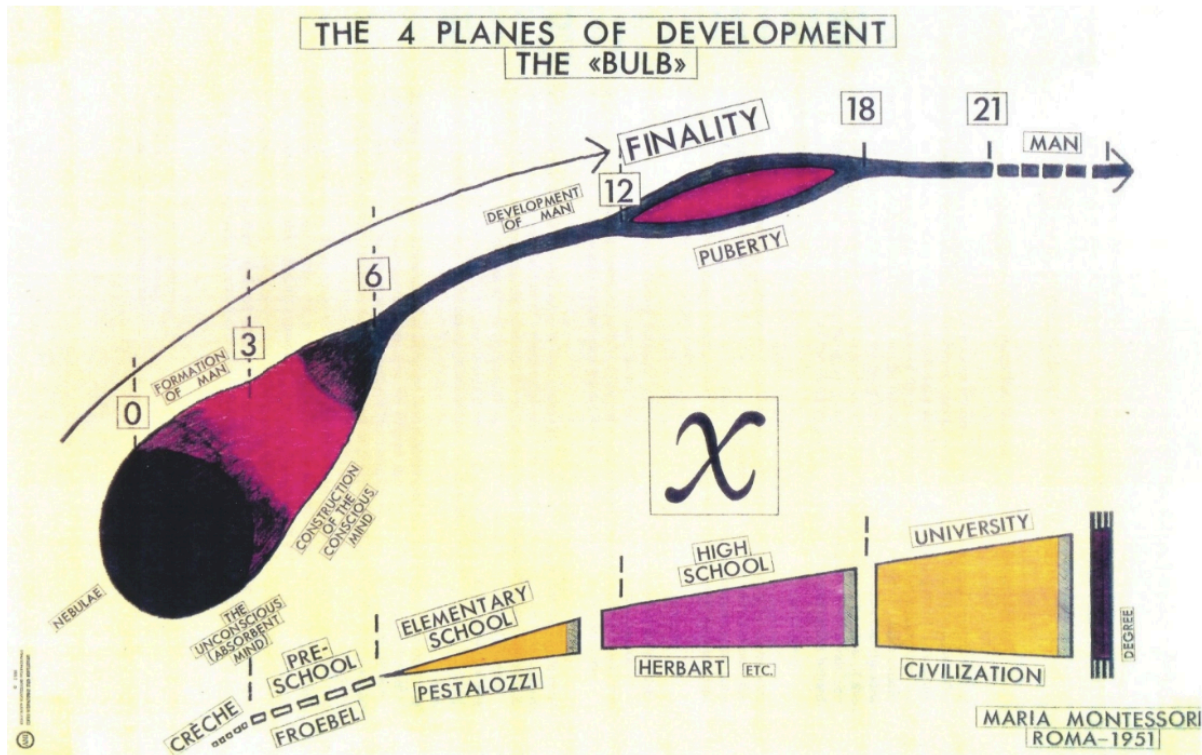
The rhythm is by 6 years: these are all approximate years. That is why we have observation because we must observe the child. 0 to 6 has 3 years of acquisition and 3 years of refinement. Development is individual and will be different for each child.

The lines of progression and regression create the triangles. Each opening of a new plane requires different needs. Each plane has a name. The first two are childhood and the second two are adulthood.

The first and third plane have developmental sensitivities which are known as sensitive periods. Both planes serve as great transformation and creation. The second plane has sensitivities but they are not as significant.

In a Montessori classroom the color red signifies a verb or energy. There are no subplanes for the 2nd and 4th planes. There is a secondary chart on the bottom about education. The arrows represent the adults working with the children. The adults cause traditional teaching. How the child turns out will be due to the teaching that is offered to the child. Finality is what the child was intended to be. More information on this chart can be found in the green book, article by Grazzini.

Chart 2: The Bulb Chart



This chart is more true to life and nature. It is a contrasting chart. Everything happens gradually. The child comes with enormous potential and energy that we need to tap into. It is not the adult that makes the child.

- ❖ 0-3 is the formation of man.
- ❖ 6-12 is the development of man
- ❖ 12-18 another bulb swelling and increase in energy. Hormones have a lot to do with this.
This is not the time to put academic pressure on adolescents.

Human Needs

Lecture Jenny Höglund on November 1, 2022

Human needs have to do with what the individual needs to thrive and survive. They include physical needs like food, shelter, clothes, transportation, and defense. Elementary students learn that they did not appear on earth until the conditions supported it. Human needs also include spiritual needs like religion, vanity, culture/arts.

- ❖ *Religion*: Montessori never speaks about a specific religion. We all have thoughts about what is right and what is wrong.
- ❖ *Vanity*: Feeling good about ourselves in the eyes of others. We all want to be liked.
- ❖ *Culture and Arts*: literature, art, music
- ❖ *Human Gifts*: hands to work, head (brain), and heart (unconditional love).

We all have the same needs but the choices that adolescents make will make a difference in their development. The environment determines how the child grows up. We create human groups to keep our cultures alive. It is comforting. An example would be the “Little Italy” neighborhood in New York City. Man can adapt to any environment and satisfy their needs. Human beings came with a gift and that is the possibility of love.

Human Tendencies

Lecture “Human Needs and Tendencies” on November 1, 2022 by Jenny Höglund

Human tendencies are from nature and animals are guided by their instincts. These are the individual's innate directives and are verbs. We all have these tendencies and they stay with us throughout life. These can sometimes be very vague but they are an individual's natural inclinations. They are universal, ever-lasting, and hereditary.

The child becomes their own individual within a group. A happy child is well adapted. We can see if these tendencies are aided or obstructed. This list of human tendencies comes from Mario Montessori's book.

❖ **Order**

Children can function independently due to order. If the environment is always changing, one feels lost in one's mind. Order is the basis for creativity and confidence. If you sustain order, the adolescents feel like they can count on you.

❖ **Orient**

Orientation helps us get to know the people and the place. It's important for children to be oriented to their environments.

❖ **Explore**

We explore for many different reasons. It is to be curious, survival, experimentation, gather information, use our senses, move, test, classify. Early humans had to explore to find food. Babies do this with their mouths. They want to find out all of the qualities. We want children to be curious and not afraid to touch things.

❖ **Observe**

Little children take in everything around them. They carefully watch how adults interact. In upper elementary, children start to observe themselves in an introspective way. Life becomes much richer if we allow the adolescents time to observe.

❖ **Communication**

Man is social and has a strong need to communicate. Pass on information to one another for survival. A child is born with the potentiality for many languages. Children who participate in conversations as a child do much better in college. As adults, they can listen to what is not being said.

❖ **Associate**

First plane works independently. The second plane starts to work socially.

❖ **Active**

Man takes possession of his environment with his hand. Especially the adolescent.

❖ **Manipulate**

Coordination of movement.

❖ **Work**

Children and adolescents work tirelessly if it is the right work, where as forced work is tiring. Busy work does not support the development. Children are motivated within while adults are externally motivated. Children get satisfaction by finishing work.

Concentration is laid out in the elementary. "Work is love made visible." by Kahlil Gibran.

❖ **Repeat**

Children do this over and over. An example is practicing a sport for improvement. Adults should not stop a child when they are repeating because we do not know when they are fulfilled. We should always offer the option for repeating.

❖ **Abstract**

Babies abstract with experiences. The process cannot be hurried. First plane abstractions are with using geometric solids. Close your eyes and pick a shape from the basket. The adult says "cube" and now the baby can learn what a cube is when they hear it.

❖ **Imagine**

In the second plane to imagine is a sensitivity. Adolescents are great at anticipatory imagination. To imagine helps us reach new theories and realities.

❖ **Self-Perfect**

As individuals, we have the desire to refine and perfect one's own self.

❖ **Control Oneself**

Movement, speech, will, impulse. Know when and how to exercise this. We want them to will themselves to do and not to do certain things.

Adaptation

Lecture on Adaptation by Jenny Höglund on November 7, 2022

The task of education is to aid life. The aim of adaptation is to help the child construct himself to the environment into which they are born. The child and the environment are in constant interaction. Child feeds the environment and the environment contributes to the transformation of the child's personality

The child adapts to physical as well as social environment and it's dictated by the way of life in the environment. This is important because it provides a foundation. Those who are well adapted to their environment have a better ability to adapt to new situations because of this firm foundation

Adaptation to the environment means happiness and feelings of ease. Provides equilibrium and a sense of security.

Do not seek out remedies, concentrate on the needs of the child. We have to understand whether the needs of the child were responded to or not. The small child absorbs his/her immediate environment. They are really interested in life and in human behavior. It's first by being in contact and studying it and that they begin to understand it.

As Montessorians, we tend to perceive Montessori's life in relation to education since that is what interests us. Montessori had a social agenda as well in relation to women's rights (voting/working/education). For her, you can't base education on an ideology that changes constantly (curriculum, etc) We have to base it on the CHILD and his/her needs and on society.

We take from our environment with our minds and our hands. We are active in our environment. We need to prepare for social life through social experiences so that children will grow a love for humanity. Man is capable of anything and prepare the environment for his/her own adaptation.

We must always see the child in relation to the environment. It's all about work on and in the environment. It's important before 6 years of life. It will become very important again after puberty but more difficult if there is not a firm foundation of self security in the environment.

Prepared Environment

Lecture by Jenny Hoglund on November 7, 2022

Two pillars of the Montessori theory are the prepared environment and limited intervention from the adult.

The environment is described as being indoor and outdoor where nature is important. It should correspond to the needs and characteristics of the child. It should have a support system so that one can become themselves. The activities depend on the adults that set them up. It should encourage development and independence. The children must find what they need to become “me”.

Every environment has materials that aid development. It is not to help the teacher. The adult's do not dictate the child's schedule. They will start to love their environment. They will have spontaneous care for the environment. The environment should have opportunities for contribution, collaboration, and freedom so that they can live and not just be taught. Children need to live in observation of nature. The child will notice patterns in nature.

The Role of the Adult

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 7, 2022

“The first duty of the teacher, no matter the age, is to recognize and respect the human personality and being.” Maria Montessori, *The Absorbent Mind*

We should make sure that all aspects of the human needs are in equilibrium.

Adults should:

- ❖ Respect the power and personality of the child. See the child who is not yet there. With the right work, the focus should be on the learner.
- ❖ Must customize lessons depending on the child.
- ❖ Collaborate with the child’s inner teacher.
- ❖ Provide purposeful work. Will this help the child’s development?
- ❖ Try to illuminate and inspire rather than instruct.
- ❖ Don’t force children on or off a material.
- ❖ Set stage for a desire or transfer of knowledge.
- ❖ We need to be what oxygen is to fire.
- ❖ Don’t forget civility and code of conduct.
- ❖ Be consistent.
- ❖ What is true for the children is also true for the adults.
- ❖ Build a joyful community based on community.
- ❖ There is nothing wrong with saying no.
- ❖ Cloth yourself in humility.

Maria Montessori was very strict on what should be presented in the first and second planes. The adults have a lot of power in the community because the children will want to follow through. We must leave our boxes and meet the child where they are.

Observation

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 11, 2022

Observation is the cornerstone of Montessori theory. It brings our work to life. Theory and practice is not enough. It is a necessity to observe the child and it is in art. It requires time, patience, and perseverance.

We must prepare for observation with method. You need to be attentive so that you know when the child is ready for a presentation. We should think of ourselves as scientists. It's really important that we put theory into practice.

When you observe in a classroom, you will be invited to sit in a chair. You should be invisible in this chair and to not engage with anyone. Don't call attention to yourself and be plain. Do not evaluate the adult or classroom. Do not make judgements about others. We have no idea what is happening in the environment. Just focus on the actions in the environment. For example, if a child is crying, you do not observe that they are sad. You observe that tears are running down the cheeks.

Here are some questions to consider when you are observing:

- ❖ How do they come into the environment?
- ❖ How work is chosen and when?
- ❖ Pay attention to noise level.
- ❖ Pay attention to each child's work choice.
- ❖ Association, tendencies, communication, individual vs. group work
- ❖ Moral orientation
- ❖ Manifestations
- ❖ Reality or fantasy?
- ❖ Work, concentration, obedience
- ❖ Care of the environment
- ❖ How do they respond to work?
- ❖ Reaction to mistakes

Work as an Aid to Development

Lecture on June 28, 2023

Work is the answer to almost everything in a Montessori context. It is a chief characteristic and fundamental instinct. Humans have worked from the start and are universal. The mind produces so many ideas which lead us to work. Human beings are modifying the environment through work. It is through work that human beings come together. Work on the environment is collective work and it leads to the distribution of labor. Each plane offers the right kind of work.

Child's Work

Children have an instinct to work, it's a human tendency. This unites us with the cosmos and the universe. In the YCC, the children work. It is not play. The materials in the classroom must have a purpose. The child uses the outside environment for his work. It has to be real work, not busy work. This urge is set by nature. When it is the right work, they do not tire. It will satisfy the inner need of the child. Adults take work from children unknowingly because they think they're helping. Without work, the individual cannot build their personality. The hand is the instrument of the mind throughout the first through third plane. Children love helping with all tasks in the first plane.

Adult's Work

The adult's have external motivations for house work. Instead of rushing, adults can slow down and spend time together with children on house work. Children need the right environment to do their work with maximum effort. *They are testing their abilities, and growing a sense of power within. Until they are satisfied with themselves. (Maria Montessori, Education for Peace)* If you get fatigued by working, you are probably working the wrong way. Children seem to be deprived of this. Adults work for a goal in mind, children work to construct themselves. Adults do work which is social, collective, and organized.

Adolescent's Work

Adolescent's work must be real and relevant work. It helps them discover their capabilities. The work can take many forms. The work is personal, social, and real adult work. Be careful when adults start to suggest projects that the "students can do." The work is not coming from the adults. Having an environment with endless possibilities creates opportunities. The adults are in charge of equipping the environment with project opportunities. Maria Montessori talks about work for the adolescent, "...different kinds of work. Economic work, spiritual work, man works for other, not for himself. All work is noble."

Residential programs foster more desire to work because it is truly their home. A smaller community is nice because you can't be larger than there is work for everyone. It is nice for everyone to be up to something daily. Adults live restrictive lives. Supernature needs nature. Nature provides food and nourishment for our psyche. *Adolescents need to find relationship between nature and humanity.* The future of the planet relies on it. Through work, you can experience normalization of the entire group.

Work is meaningful, with purpose, and when you do this kind of work, you can see it as a moral training. When you value work, you value the work of others. The right kind of work produces an intense urge. Through work comes freedom and independence. *Renilde Montessori said, "Work is a human right and privilege."*

Ask yourself, "*Do I think of work as a privilege?*" We want the adolescents to discover this. When they start to appreciate work, it will stay for life and they will value their peers too. The right kind of work creates a love for the environment.

First Plane: Protect and Nurture

Second Plane: Sew Seeds of Culture

Third Plane: Tend and Feed the cultivating mind and provide environment that satisfies their needs and sensitivities.

Valorization

April 9, 2024, Jenny Hoglund

I think over the many years I have been working with adolescents, I have seen glimpses of valorization. This lecture is how I see valorization, in the light of Montessori's writings and my own experiences.

Montessori describes valorization as being something from across all four planes. We have an idea of what it means, but we have difficulty pinpointing its nature. In order to understand valorization, I start by thinking what it is not.

It is not just a third plane phenomena. In *Moral and Social Education*, Montessori spoke about valorization of the younger children. It is not just feeling good about oneself, but it has to do with our perception, concepts, and attitudes about oneself. It is not what someone does to you. No one can valorize another person. So, if someone does something of any kind you cannot say, "You must feel so valorized now!" That is not how it happens. It is also not just to be loved.

It is difficult to define, and yet, it is a very important aspect of a child's development across the planes and maybe more so for the third plane. Valorization offers a glimpse of what optimal development could look like. It really changes the adolescent. In my mind, it happens when the work is right. Which means that we need to have an understanding of what the right work is.

The right work is very much connected to independence. It is also connected to social experiences. Whether it is society by cohesion in the first plane, or social organization created by the elementary, all of these aspects come from the prepared environment. But then, these also have to be the right kinds of environments.

The term valorization is found in various places in Montessori's writings. Sometimes it is used as a verb, to valorize. But most of the time it is in the context of the valorization of the personality. She also mentions valorization of mankind. I've been thinking a lot about that. Maybe that is the state of *peace and humanity as a collective*.

There is one thing that education can take as a sure guide, and that is the *personality of the child* who is to be educated. The first duty of the educator, whether it is an infant or older child, is to recognize the human personality of the young being and respect it. Education is an aid to life and life includes mind, intelligence, and personality. We know that education then has to help the child to develop their personality. This is true for the third plane when Montessori speaks about the formation of personality.

In the *Formation of Man*, Montessori writes that we need to consider the human personality and *not the method of education*. We have to provide help so that the human personality can achieve its independence. What is understood by the personality which is to be valorized. Its object, *Montessori says*, is to influence the whole life of the child. It aims at the total development of the personality, a harmonious growth of all of the potentialities of the child according to the laws of its being.

Then, *Montessori writes*, education should no longer be in imparting knowledge, but must take a new path in seeking the release of human potentialities. Our answer is that the greatness of human personality begins at birth.

Mario writes that these potentialities (which are infinite) have to be exercised if they are not to disappear. We can't just focus on one aspect of development, it has to be holistic. Nature provides help with the human tendencies. These direct us according to our attitude toward life: possession, power, and an easy life. The tendencies help us develop the personality and build an individual that is suited to their time.

Sensitivities and adaptation all support this natural development. So, personality, and its organization is at the essence of Montessori's approach. So personality is organized and developed through the guidance of these natural laws that are there. And the laws that are brought forward get an opportunity to work if we allow for spontaneous activity in a prepared environment.

We know that when there is a healthy organization of personality, it is known as character. You are using your language, intelligence, and behavior in a virtuous way. Montessorians are convinced that the child is held back by the adults from valorizing his personality. It is the attitude of the whole of society and education that does its utmost to devalorize the child. (relates to the Kodaikanal essay in Communication 2010.)

Above all, it is a social experience, which valorizes the human personality. Social experiences are to be paid attention to, because it is in society that the child's potentialities are to be realized. Montessori says, so the child valorizes his personality even when they are younger than 3. Children need a certain amount of social life and independence. These are serious needs in his life. Throughout his own efforts, he can be independent and achieve things he sets his mind to do.

There has to be independence, he has to be allowed to try, and it has to be his or her efforts that they achieve on their own. This means that we must find a very practical way to base education on, so that the personality can be valorized.

It is work in the environment, the right kind of work, that requires maximum effort. For the young children we speak about busy work; this is not developmental, but it just makes them be still for a few minutes. This is not what we are talking about here.

*With adolescents we have to think about, do we offer them busy busy work? Or is it **real work**?*

Then there is *freedom*, so that independence can be achieved by one's own efforts. Valorization takes place when the environment is right and the work is right. When I took my training, I learned that Montessori is very much about ***work and independence***. If you look at it in that way, it makes it simple. Work and independence- it sounds very simple when we see it this way. What does not make it simple is that we must decode what the 'right work' is. As adults, we have a tendency to view work in a different way than children or adolescents. The work we are talking about is not school work. It is not a 9 to 5 job, it is not a paid position. We know that work is important from many points of view. One of the reasons for this is our understanding of work to what end? *Why do we do the work that we do?* Why do we offer the work we offer? It is our understanding of this question that will give us the direction that we need to take with our children and adolescents.

So, to understand work, which we still struggle with, this is far more important than we think. I think we offer it all day continuously. **“What will you work with today?”** Work is a human tendency and we all have a desire to engage in meaningful work. Young children follow an inner drive to work. They are active. They don't have to be made to do this. They need to be active because they work for their inner development. When Montessori understood that, she made it clear that it was work. It wasn't about play. It was something she appreciated too. She used the word work because it was about satisfying one's inner needs. That is how the child develops.

We know the importance of letting the child carry out his or her work, until they are satisfied. We don't force a child on a piece of material or off a piece of material. It has to come from within. Montessori talks about how a child who has worked has developed a special skill and ability, and something within himself. “The child learns and makes use of what he has learned, it is only after he has learned that the formative activity begins.”

Then there is the social aspect of community. This comes from the observations that Montessori made. She saw that the child works better when he finds himself in what she refers to as “voluntary association with other children.” and we know that there is a human tendency to associate. There has to be social experiences, and it is these experiences that will help develop

the morality- the moral strength within a child. There is a moral aspect of the personality. This is also part of the prepared environment. We are not just considering the physical environments. It must offer social context to the child. Morality always needs a social context, or it becomes redundant. It needs a relation between individuals. It's our association with each other that is the basis of social life.

Montessori says that when one is capable of developing one's own personality, they can enter social life harmoniously. This emerges the understanding that humans are not here to just work for themselves but to work for the community. All social life is based upon the work of man.

Montessori writes that it is evident that if man merely thinks of work to provide a living, then it is much lower than the man who works to build up the cosmic world and help a neighbor.

This is the work of love made visible.

Montessori says that intelligence can only develop if it is combined with activity. The work of the hand is an instrument of the mind. Then she says that it is not only being able to do something that helps intelligence, but having the sensation of being capable of doing something. Being aware of one's capabilities.

Montessori continued her studies, she taught at university of rome in anthropology, she studied psychology, and got her PhD.

She wanted to see what the results were if she worked with elementary children who did not have any diverse challenges. But, she was not allowed to because she wasn't a trained teacher. So, she had to work with younger children. That worked in our favor...that is where she witnessed normalization. She says that this was the single most influential part of our work. She said that less desirable qualities disappeared, and she was able to see the child as who they were meant to be.

This construction of personality happens through work. The environment has to be free from the will of a dominating adult. There are two pillars in Montessori: the prepared environment, and the limited intervention of the adult.

Upon these characteristics, Montessori describes that he is ready to give up his possessions, and is ready to embrace a new life of activity, love, which enables him to work with joy and without fatigue.

A child who achieves this change with the greatest ease, becomes therefore, man's guide to normality. There Montessori writes about this new man in Education and PEace, showing discipline but not blind submission. Have the ability to relate to reality. Which is different from flights of fancy. Montessori says that only after this new child has emerged, is education possible. This is why the first plane is crucial. It is where the foundation is laid.

Independence is also the basis for the development of personality. She says that it is upon independence as the basis, that we can organize new education and schools. Montessori writes that liberty and freedom is the independence required by one's own effort.

For valorization of a child's personality there must be a basis in social experience. This is true for small and older children. If we continue on the theme of independence, we know that for the second plane children, Montessori speaks about two independencies: mental (help me to think for myself) and the other is moral independence.

Mental independence, the way we are to understand it is (help me to think for myself.) Intellectual independence comes in the fourth plane, and it is a different kind of independence. This is when you have a depth of knowledge that can help you think for yourself as an adult.

He won't feel valorized doing things that he already did in the first plane. Elementary students start to experience the power of the group. What you can achieve when you work together. And that is when they work best. They need to work in groups for development to happen.

With the special 6 years old...you can spend extra time with them each day on writing, reading..etc.

If a child is behind (the special 12 years old), we have to help those that are behind to help them get up to speed. But, it can be done in a different way. It's not so much about bringing out the decimal board- it might work better with the farm manager outside calculating something that takes decimals. We can't just pin them down and say, we notice you don't know decimal fractions and pin them down and force them. You must find how to incorporate it in a variety of ways, so that they don't feel we are doing remedial work with them. They know that themselves, when they are behind.

Everyone realizes that at this stage children have great interest in history, but it is not the study by assimilation that one gets into orthodox schools. They are orienting and valorizing themselves in society.

Just as an older child is not valorized because he can button his coat, an older child is not independent just because he can dress and cook for himself. He has already accomplished these experiences. This gives a sense of dignity. Being worthy of honor or esteem.

Montessori adds that this production also allows for a great many activities, not directly concerned with studying. Work, we know, is an important part of independence. She says that all work is noble, so we must make sure that we offer experiences of both manual and intellectual work.

Richard Sennett said that "if there is divorce between the head and the hands, it is the head that will suffer."

This attitude towards work, which actually comes from the first plane, Is actually a characteristic for the first plane. Love of work. This is something that stays with you throughout life. We know for the adolescent, if they are to be valorized, it must be real adult work with all the

responsibility that comes with it. Above all, it is essential that the young adult must be able to have the feeling of living his own life and that he's able to shift for himself.

Montessori says that at puberty, another form of intercourse arises, society is conceived of as work. Families tend to do too much for the adolescent, at a time when the social instincts of the adolescent are forming. The adolescent needs to be freed from the overwhelming influences of home and school. He needs a prepared environment that provides social experiences, that offers solitude, the atmosphere of calm and peace, this is necessary so that the young adult may have the chance to develop his vocation. She challenges us that if we provide the right social and physical environments, that we will experience a steadily increasing capacity to love, to work, and adapt to the world.

There will be an increasing capacity to work and adapt to their social organization. You can see them move from the self to “us”. When we read the four planes of education, she says that this is the stage at which vocation occurs. She makes it clear that there is a need to serve. This is something that needs to be fostered in our environments. How do our adolescents have the opportunity to serve one another? In a community, there are usually many opportunities for this. John MacNamara said that there are some needs of the adolescent that have to be addressed. He mentioned affirmation, power, contribution, purpose, and challenge. All of these needs require a prepared environment.

The adolescents need to be in charge with the understanding that nothing will be done if they don't do it themselves. This provides them with a purpose. They have to see the significance of what they are doing. It's a sense of purpose that strengthens their relationships. Wendell Berry (American poet) says “ you cannot know who you are until you know where you are.”

Work in the environment, work for the community, work in nature, work which allows them to construct themselves as adults. The adolescents need to discover their attitudes, perceptions..etc. they have created a potential, and now they have to realize their potential. If they don't, they

probably will not ever feel valorized. This is also how they get a realistic view of who they are. They get there because of the work they do in the environment and community. Self-expression work opportunities shape their social awareness in a way that was different before. This is why “help us to do it by ourselves” is so important.” In the french addition of childhood to adolescence, “valorization” is not used. The french translation described it as. “succeed in life and by his own efforts and will be in touch with his supreme reality of life.”

Economic independence that is based on one's own initiative. It's not because your parents have given you this opportunity. This is how they get to know themselves and the society they are a part of.

The adolescents get to know who they are, when they are in the environment that Montessori envisioned for them. They get to know themselves in a very different way than if they were in a traditional classroom environment.

Ultimately an adult who can work for the good of humanity and participate in humanity's mission on this earth. It's a young adult that has a conscious interaction with the environment, including people, based on knowledge and work. There is this growing awareness of one's individual history, through which one has developed through one's personality about one's view of the world.

Just as a child becomes normalized through work, we can also speak about a community of being normalized through the collaborative work that they do. This is not something that Montessori says, but something that I've been thinking about. When I consider the community and how they live their life. It looks to me sometimes that the community becomes normalized. The environment should give opportunities for the child to be his best self through the right work. That is what Montessori offers in the “prepared environment.” We also need to account for the young children that we are not a home, but just an addition to the home. They go home to their other environments. We need to be aware of collaboration with the parents to help them in their home environments. It takes time. That is why Montessori talks about development through age

24. Adolescents do not have the intellectual and spiritual strength of adults. It takes many years to build that kind of character that will make a difference.

Jenny met with some graduates and asked them about 'work.' Because work is very important for valorization to happen. The first type of work is the work that is necessary for study, to become socially independent, to take responsibility without being asked. They could identify different kinds of work: work for the common good, care of animals, care of household, garden work, and production. They said that this was good for their social responsibility. It was good for their moral development and that is when they understood the necessity of division of labor. They said it is this work that led them to take responsibility without being asked. Without this work, other work and study cannot happen.

Second, *they looked at work which arises from a need.* This is work that has to be planned in order to meet a need. They talked about conscious and collaborative work to improve the environment.

The third work *that they identified was the Study and Work*, where they could follow their own interests.

The fourth kind of work is production which has to be every day work as a contribution to their community. That is also when they can engage with the wider society. We know that it is work that gives social and economic independence. Margaret Mead wrote that the ideal culture is the one that finds a place for every human gift; I think that that is what the environment needs to offer. That is also part of valorization.

We speak about responsibility and I think that elementary children have come to realize that there is a cosmic responsibility. Adolescents come to realize the social and ethical responsibilities. Elementary children may start to become aware of this. Adolescents are drawn to social problems. This sensitivity towards justice or high ideals, we have to enhance and see how humanity can construct for the good of all. It just has to be materialized for them.

Montessori says that social life is an organization of human beings, each feeling his responsibility in relation to the collective order. She is speaking about the social climate of solidarity and collaboration. In the environment there is a place for every human gift, so there should be no exclusion of the weak because there is room for every gift. This is why I left the traditional schools because there was nowhere for the students to make use of their gifts. There was only room for academic gifts from the textbooks. But there are other gifts that need to be appreciated. There is a difference in being just a member of society, and knowing that you can contribute to this society, in a way where others depend on your contribution.

Greeting in the morning is so important- it's your spiritual, physical, connection to them. Maybe just that instance for the entire day. Do they feel that they are needed, wanted, and essential in the community? Would we *truly* miss them if they were not there? The answer for each person should be yes. Because they are an essential piece. They need to feel that for valorization to happen and it needs to be true.

It's hard for people to see that their efforts make a difference for the broader good. That's why it is important for adolescents to live in smaller communities, so that they can see the effects of their contributions. Education produces the future. It is a help to life. Education is also about hope. I think that is true for us too. If we are not optimistic about what we are doing, then what would be the point?

This has to do with having practical life skills. Being able to fend for oneself, to serve others, being able to relate to peers and adults, take a moral stance when needed, developing a personal identity, being true to yourself, and not being a copy of someone else. Being able to make decisions and direct one's own life. But also have the flexibility, and open mind and heart. To be willing to take charge.

Montessori says that the social experience begun earlier must be continued, because the person who has never worked or tried to make his own living, and someone who has not mingled with someone different from his own age. This is how we will have a child in peace with himself. The

adolescent needs all of these different kinds of experiences to develop. Allowing them to set goals for themselves and be in an environment where they can develop a positive attitude about themselves. Peace is a very practical part of human civilization. We speak of it in grand terms, but it is a practical principle.

So, valorization then, is beginning to become aware of one's capabilities, assets, and one's weaknesses, it is an awareness that comes from within, and not what someone else prescribed you. It is due to growth of one's work, it is the succession of achieving one's independence in a corresponded social environment. It is heading towards maturity and coordination of all of one's potentialities.

Valorization is not a recipe that we can follow or prescribe. It will be different for each adolescent, because it comes from within. Our goal is to set up an environment to provide the adolescent with a life well-lived, and offering them experiences that give them a sense of independence, purpose, and feeling of themselves being a true asset to the community. The adolescents read from Childhood to Adolescents.

The Life of Maria Montessori

Jenny Hoglund, April 17, 2024

Maria Montessori was Italian. She was born in 1870. Her parents were Allesandro Montessori and Renilde Stepani. In her childhood home there is a plaque on the door that says, “Maria Montessori, born August 31, 1870, famous pedagog and creator of a sound method of education that helped students open their minds...”

In 1870, 58% of people lived in the countryside of Italy. There were almost 30 million people who lived there.

For women in the early 1900's if they were not stay at home mothers, the only option was to be a teacher. So, she said that she would never be a teacher. She wanted to become a doctor. It was very difficult for her because she had to study, but women and men couldn't study alone together, so she would have to do her practice at night...etc. But, she became a Medical Doctor.

With her medical studies she also took up women's rights. She was invited to speak for women's rights in the same year that she graduated from medical school.

She started to work with children who had diverse capacities and at the time they called the children 'idiots.' But after a while of observing the children, she realized that the children had very passive lives and it was a pedagogical problem because they had been shunned from society.

She studied the scientific methods of Eduardo Seguin and used these observational techniques with the children. She wanted to work with elementary children, but wasn't allowed because she wasn't a trained teacher. So, she had to work with young children and this is how the first Casa

dei Bambini started in Rome in 1907. Children ages 3 to 7 were supported all day by Montessori or her assistants. They came at 8hr00am and left at 18hr00.

They had a cupboard with all of the materials for the children and one morning they came to school and the cupboard was unlocked and the children were working independently. This is when the need for freedom of choice and independent work became very clear to her.

Montessori had an outcome and goal in mind. She had faith that change was possible. Students started caring for themselves because of the different activities that they did. The children also started to come home and bring these practices to their homes: cleaning the environment, clean clothes...etc., it started to transform the neighborhood too. She believed that if we can do this for the children, then each and every child will get the fair chance to live their lives according to their potential.

Montessori was worried that adults had many preconceived ideas about children. She found that if you respect children and make sure that you don't violate their integrity, then they will respond and behave very differently. She saw that when she treated the children this way, they left some of these negative characteristics aside.

Montessori started to figure out that the environment needed to be prepared to cater to the needs of the children and not to the adults. She also realized that the children needed to be free and active, and they would learn on their own through the practical experiences in their environment. She noticed that children enjoy learning and like to learn for themselves.

At the same time, she started to put her experience at Casa dei Bambini into perspective. She realized that all children had this potential in themselves. Her idea was that each and every child has the opportunity to develop as they are meant to, then we will have adults who are harmonious, mindful, and respectful of all beings. That is when she realized that there could be peace on earth, if we start with the child.

She traveled all over the world: to the states, India...etc. Mario and Maria became under house arrest in India. Montessori pedagogy really started to spread. She started to understand that after people came to her lectures and training, people went away with different things in mind. She realized that not everyone practiced exactly how she described it. So in 1929 AMI was founded in Berlin to protect her work and pedagogy. Every 4th year there is an AMI congress. The first one was in Denmark, and most recently there was one in Thailand in August 2023.

Pope Benedict was very interested in Montessori, so they have Montessori's writings in the Vatican library. In 1935, AMI headquarters moved to Amsterdam. Montessori spent many years in Barcelona, but went back to Italy. But, Montessori got into a disagreement with Muesellini and he closed all of the Montessori schools in Italy. The AMI Amsterdam headquarters is in the house that Maria Montessori used to live in. They still have her study furnished as it was when she lived there. You can go visit and knock and they will let you in. They have an archive of her work too. In her study, you can see her nomination for the Nobel Peace Prize, and other awards that she received from France, and the Dutch Royal family.

She had a very long life. There are many books about her, and she wrote many books. When you read Montessori, you should consider reading her books in chronological order. You can really see how her thinking evolved over time. She died on May 6, 1952 when she was planning a trip to Africa. There are many books about her and her life.

- ❖ Maria Montessori, "The Life and Work of Montessori" by E.M. Standing. He was a friend.
- ❖ Mamolina, children's book.
- ❖ Cultivator of the Human Spirit, Punum Bhatia
- ❖ Sheila Radice
- ❖ A Montessori Journey
- ❖ Maria Montessori: letters, a Centenary Anthology by

Human Solidarity

Jenny Hoglund, April 19, 2024

In Appendix C, Montessori says that when the individual arrives at University, they are already a formed person with a social destiny. This destiny depends on what has been going on before in the person's life.

Montessori says that the children's development into independent and mature personalities depend on their future education. It is a mistake to think that this development will happen on its own accord. Personal experiences during childhood determine the role they play with the personality.

Montessori says that the stages of development come on top of each other, but they do so without destroying each other. Instead, they enlarge the soul more and more. The children's work is for development. It's an internal work. Then, we have adult work. The work of the adult is external and aimed at the environment.

We know that therefore, in order to make this a smooth transition for the adolescent, we know that their developmental task is to participate in the workings of society, learning to do adult work. These experiences need to be concrete and not abstract. Adaptability is an important quality. Young people need to be prepared for changes in society. They need to be able to recognize possibilities. They shouldn't train for specific careers, but Montessori says education should aim at many sides and adaptability so that they can later (in the fourth plane) have a higher level of moral conscience and fully accept the responsibility that is attached to their lives.

For this type of education, Montessori presents a syllabus for academic study. It has a lot of history on it. It is through history that students start to relate themselves to humanity. It also helps in their ethical thinking. If you ever study Ancient Greece, you see that their whole lives were an ethical matter. For them, to live well, involved all aspects and not just the surface-level mundane living.

Knowledge has to be based on understanding and this is where education comes into play. In Europe there used to be an education called “Liberal Education.” It was an education about thinking and being clear in one’s mind about their beliefs. It was an education that included the arts, humanities, science, and practical subjects. They were introduced to many facets of life and had to learn so many different things. Scientists have a very broad education with a variety of topics and philosophy. *Cicero said that history is the teacher of life.* In doing so, literature and arts is included in there, and helps them to live more reflectively and knowledgeable especially about history and the nature of the society.

History is there to present to the students an insight into the great possibilities that exist for people when they live in sympathy and solidarity.

The aim is to make the students aware of how essential it is to think about the consequences of one's own choices and actions. Such an education through history, and with ethical thinking, will encompass all that science can offer and threaten, and all that life can offer and threaten.

History is to aid development, not to make them memorize years and events. It is there to help the adolescents to feel part of humanity. We do history in order to help build and feed human solidarity. That is the underlying aim of history. Montessori didn’t divide up history into any categories by year. History is history. She says that our history begins with the creation of earth as well as the coming of life. “Big History” The 6 Cosmic Fables open the doors to big historical events. We are all made out of stardust. We are related to all forms of life. This is a very grand view but it explains why it contributes to all of humanity, life, and human solidarity.

Montessori says that there should be this kind of framework because most schools start with their national history. But, Montessori says that this should be the end of their history lessons. They should learn from the start of life so that every nation is involved here and see the earth as a whole. That’s why we start with the elementary with this great whole that everything fits in to.

If you study the history of mathematics you may end up in Alexandria with the philosophers and mathematicians and the famous library that was destroyed. As you move along you get to know so much about the social and religious history just looking into one discipline. It also lets them know that history also includes normal human beings, it's not just about famous people. They get to know the people who also made discoveries but their work was taken by others.

Montessori says that human beings throughout history are not just bodies but they are spirits. They had thoughts and they did things to try to make their thoughts concrete. Traditional history often focuses on the negative aspects, whereas Montessori thought that we should have a positive approach to history so that the adolescents want to step into this story and continue the work. Of course, there are things that we should never forget, terrible things.

Some quotes about history:

"History is indeed little more than the register of misfortune, follies of mankind."

George Orwell said, "He who controls the past commands the future..."

Abrose Bierce "History is an account mostly unimportant which are brought about by rulers, fools, George Santayana Philosophers "those who don't remember the past are condemned to repeat it."

We want adolescents to feel good about history so that they want to belong to society. We come with gifts that are unique to humans: love, intelligence, and work of the hand and they see how these gifts can be used in a very good way- working for the good of all.

In Montessori education we speak about Humans and Earth, then Life and Humanity. The students are shown how the gifts of humans can be used for good. Then we have the cosmic fables like the Ox and the House story from Mario. It has to do with the alphabet in Hebrew.

It is an interesting consideration to think about your social media profiles and see that what you post will always be out there. The usage of language reflects how we live our lives according to time, place, and person. These words which are symbolic, stemming from an agreement reached

from members of a community, but are still so powerful and they can convey feelings, persuade, comfort, hurt, inform, and soothe.

Elementary students say “help me to think for myself” there is a mental independence. It’s very important that you can read an article and read a book and understand what is being said there without having to rely on someone else. Language helps human beings to function in an organized way. No collective task could be accomplished without language. Language is such a precious gift that has been handed down to us and we may never understand the effort that it took. What great power came from language. You are in a very good position when you have strong language. Language is a gift that brought us together to communicate, wide and far. Then, at the end we should look at the history of our own country. There is a story of all nations, but it is important to show that it is a part of a wider world.

If you have an elementary community near the adolescent community, it’s important to borrow their timelines of civilization. It’s nice for adolescents to look at these. It also comes with a map so that they can look up where these areas are.

Montessori gave us **three keys** of history which are the fundamental human needs charts. They constitute the guide for all human beings. These needs are universal; we share them just by being human. From this point of view, we are all equal in sharing these needs. There are differences in society and as individuals. The needs bind us together. But, there are differences in how they are satisfied. Because of these differences, human groups have developed different physical and spiritual territories. The word “fundamental” is there to tell us that these needs are crucial and necessary for us to survive in a fully human sense. We also need our spiritual needs satisfied. This is a way to approach human society and to explore humanity.

All human beings are in an environment that nature provides for us, and still, human beings in all different places and times, they use the environment to build their supernature. Because of this, we can share things about the environment.

Migration is another key to history. The idea that human groups develop different knowledge depending on their circumstances. Our children know about migration as immigration and not always in a positive sense. It's not just people who migrated, it's also food, people, and clothing. Why did people migrate here? It's good to understand this. Also how immigrants enrich our lives and knowledge. It's the idea of a collective humanity that Montessori has in mind.

Another key to history is **time**. History unfolds overtime. It does so in a particular sequence. History is always embedded in time.

So where does this lead us now? It leads us to understand human beings, where we came from, who we are, and why we are what we are. They explore the story of human time and the needs of migration. They understand the lives of ordinary people. Which is also important. Some ordinary person is plowing their field and they come across a discovery. They realize that they too can make impacts like this. They come to look at all sorts of inventions and discoveries as human beings. They try to make their lives more secure and comfortable. In the educational syllabus there is a history of human progress. Very few inventions happened solo. It was usually a collective effort.

One of the points that Montessori makes is to make our students aware that humanity is a single nation and we really can't live in an isolated way. I think she was really sad about this and she spoke about it at the end of her life. And she said that we failed to see our similarities and that we lived like we were all so different. She said that we live by the fact of what we don't have. We are also driven by fear, but we don't want them to be in that position. To lose what you have. Young children and adolescents are not driven by fear. They can be driven by not having the latest things, but most of them are not competitive either.

H.G. Wells wrote that human history becomes more and more a race between education and catastrophe. This is not very optimistic. Most students when they move to adolescents, they have encountered the Story of the Great River. This is where Montessori compares society to the human body. The collaboration of the cells and the interdependence. There are consequences for the future

because of our actions. The understanding of us being one nation is very important. La Nazione Unica. Cells can be specialized, but they still serve the whole. Do we need to serve the whole?

It all started very simply. This single nation has The earth's riches belong to all. The fear of poverty must disappear. Our underlying aim is human solidarity. What we offer our students are bonds that cross boundaries and give them the idea of how they can serve the whole, be dependent on one another, and give them feelings of solidarity. Montessori says I can never insist enough, the importance of the study of history with the goal of realizing human solidarity. We want this to blossom in the children. Human beings are powerful and where is this power taking us? How do we move towards human solidarity and social responsibility? She said we have to radically change the way we look at human relations. We must be endeavoring to man's consciousness, fighting indifference.

The moments in life where we should have done something, will not be repeated. All situations need to be responded to in a responsible way. This is in the hands of the educators. Because political systems will not get us there.

Montessori said in Citizen of the World, "Our task as educators is to ensure that an intense consciousness of universality solidarity will flourish within the children." This is not done through reading books or preaching. This is so big it is hard to talk about. But, I think it has to do with giving the opportunity for a life well lived, and not sure well taught, but well-lived with others so that it is understood how interdependent we are. How are choices and actions will make a difference. It is a question of work from a different point of view. It's about good and great work.

Montessori says that only a man that has transformed himself will be capable of forming a different society. Our task then is to offer adolescents the possibility for personality to develop as a real asset in human society. Then, the idea that is so well planted in the elementary, that there is not succeeding unless we all succeed. We have to think in these terms. It's not just about cleaning up the environment. It's about caring on a deeper level. Making sure that everyone lives in an environment that is positive.

First Plane of Development

Theory

The Child's Task

Lecture by Rukmini Ramachandran on November 2, 2022

From birth the human child is born to work. Born with a unique mind unlike any, this is unique from 0 to 6 years old. It is the work of the unconscious mind. Montessori figured this out due to her incredible ability to observe.

Montessori's work is on both sides of science and philosophy. She talks about the camera and how the mind captures pictures that are instantaneous and exact. Just like when you are waiting for film to develop, the child absorbs things that we had no idea they could absorb. The young child's mind is a mystery. The cones in his eyes are not yet developed. Observation has great weight the baby observes from birth and has a deep connection with the environment.

The physical objects are observed as well as the adult's emotions and attitudes. All of the experiences around him are nourishing the mind. The child is born without anything, so his environment teaches him everything. The first six years are the foundations for his whole life.

The baby is guided through life by nature. The child's will is the beginning of will and freedom. Human beings are characterized by the will to choose. We think the young child should be given this and that but not receiving everything is how they learn to self-regulate. The goal of life is to live in harmony with one another. Once they've learned their culture it stays with the child forever. There is a very urgent time for adaptation and for the child to fix his personality.

As adults, we take in experiences and filter them based on our past experiences. The children, they just experience and they don't interpret. You cannot reach them with the reasoning mind. After 6 years of age, the child will be able to interpret. We hope for the child to have positive experiences to observe in these formative years.

Spiritual Embryo

Lecture by Rukmini Ramachandran on November 2, 2022

The first three years of the child's life is that of acquisition. The idea of the "spiritual embryo" is often discussed in Montessori theory. Everything that is not physical is spiritual. Embryo comes from the origin meaning "full of potential." Think of a seed. The potential of the blooming plant is within.

There comes a time when the fetus is ready to change the environment. They adapt to their new dry environment and the child is completely dependent on the adult. The needs of the child are love, security, order, and the child's task is to create themselves. The child also takes in the language from their environment.

After 3 years old the basic acquisition is complete. They've been forming at home. This is not a physical expression of the word. Home= spiritual and physical. Home is the center of the spirit. It is different for each individual where the child builds their sense of comfort and belonging. The home must include the child. They shouldn't just be transferred from container to container. Love and inclusivity is the wealth of the home. The baby has impulse but the will helps them self-regulate. Celebrate the child's first "no!". During 0-3 years old using order, the child can construct his mind and organization.

Powers of the Child

Lecture by Rukmini Ramachandran on November 2, 2022

The baby is born, nothing is established but everything is potential. We all have permanent adaptations, it depends on the culture that we identify with. The child uses the power of the mind to create the faculty of language. The child doesn't see color as a newborn.

The child has two powers.

1. Absorbent Mind: The absorbent mind describes the child's brain during the first plane of development from birth to 6 years old. They soak in everything about the environment around them. This includes the traditions, language, and the social environment. They do this through observation. The child takes in everything to construct themselves. By the age of 6 the absorbent mind vanishes. This is why we have a sense of urgency.

The child has so much strength. We don't understand the energy and strength of a child. They are not helpless. We can do for the child but we must respect their will. We must recognize their physical strength. They are natural yogis. Children benefit greatly from seeing a task from start to finish. Having a great struggle and then sitting their work to fruition. If children are never able to reach this point, they will have struggle between adult and child. Even children with physical differences, don't put your limiting standards on them. Each child is individual. What can they do and how much can they do? Support as much independence as possible.

2. Attraction to the Environment: This is a sensitive period for the environment and observation.

Children who arrive in the Montessori environment after 6 years old can be helped to re-establish what they haven't acquired. Things can be put off or wait until later but parents need to know

how crucial 0-6 years is. It's important that children don't miss school during this time. If a child comes without knowing how to speak, write, or is behind in another way, they may need a specialist but don't forget to support the heart. They need to feel encouraged and supported most of all.

The Education and Movement

November 2, 2022 by Rukmini Ramachandran

Maria uses this word in an interesting way. “The control of oneself”. This is self regulation and the will to do what we want. There is a movement chart on page 144 of *The Absorbent Mind*.

First level of movement in a child’s life they are cleaned, sootherd, bathed, taken care of, dressed, and their environment is cared for. How the adult cares for the environment is their first experience of movement.

Skills are developed with both the mind and the body. We reach harmony when we see our tasks to fruition. Our modern society is always rushed and our practical care and life has dissolved. Children are drawn to practical house work and the conquest of movement. The idea of practical life is education. It is an aid to life. Human movement is spiritual because it is achieved through body and mind. Purposeful movement creates inner peace.

Children self-construct through this practical life work. Through the caring of self and the environment they learn to self regulate. For the first two years of life, sweeping, vacuuming, and washing is wondrous for the child! The children experience and learn through the adults movement. Practical life is the foundation of life.

Logic and movement are the basis for self construction. This is also very important in adolescence. To further this topic read the *Discovery of Child and Movement*.

The Construction of the Intelligence

Lecture from Rukmini Ramachandran on November 3, 2023

The first Children's house opened in 1907 called Casa di Bambini. It was for 2.5 to 6 years old.

What do we do in casa?

- ❖ Practice practical life. Dusting, sitting at the table, mopping, putting clothes on, pouring water. If they've been practicing life at home, this should be a smooth transition for them.
- ❖ The mixed age in casa helps to grow the intelligence
- ❖ Washing hands, cutting and peeling fruit, washing table, sweeping floor

Practical life has a sequence. They may stumble at first but they will lay the logical framework. The 3 to 6 child starts to refine what they have acquired. The child is not a conscious worker. Keeping the home organized is important and this is internalized by 3. Children internalize qualities of items through experiences. This also leads to recalling images and organizing qualities in the mind. This is abstraction.

For example: the pink cube helps create order by putting it in order from biggest to smallest.

The basis of comparison from one item to another:

- ❖ Contrast
- ❖ Identity
- ❖ Similarities
- ❖ Differences

Decision making is the basis for constructing of intelligence. Comparing and contrasting from a young age makes for a well adjusted and capable life.

Concentration

Lecture from Rukmini Ramachandran on November 3, 2023

The child's work is the most important in self-construction. The process of concentration starts with:

- ❖ Identifying a problem
- ❖ Polarization of attention
- ❖ Repetition or effort
- ❖ Refreshed and wakes up

Interruption breaks the path to concentration. You cannot tell a child to focus or concentrate. If the challenge is too great the child will not concentrate. If it is too easy, they also will not concentrate. It is the difficulty that holds interest. Interest also needs spontaneous choice. When they are focused they start to lose self-awareness. This is concentration.

Example: A child did the pink tower 23 times. The teacher was delighted to see this concentration. It is not about the teacher or my school, or my class, this is all about the child. The child harnesses their own power.

Error goes hand in hand with concentration. Error represents a challenge. Error is part of a larger process. You must observe and error will tell us where the child is. Error lets us peek into the mind.

People want to correct the child but once we intervene we:

- ❖ Prevent them from correcting their own errors
- ❖ We make them under confident

For supplemental reading, *The Absorbent Mind*, ch. 22. Also, page 201.

Concentration causes an inner spiritual shift that changes the child. They can be very different activities for each child. Self-discipline also goes with concentration. We think of work as the opposite of play and leisure, but being idle is the opposite of work.

The Foundation of Language

Lecture from Rukmini Ramachandran on November 3, 2023

The baby enters a rich linguistic environment. When you talk to a baby at 2 months old they recognize human language as something unique. The child acquires the language. They deepen their understanding through experience. Language is an agreement and a sequence. The oldest words are nouns. See the language chart on page 128 of *The Absorbent Mind*.

Language transcends time. Animals leave their bones but humans leave their thoughts. You prepare children for writing by speaking.

- ❖ Listen
- ❖ Speak
- ❖ Write
- ❖ Read

Force does not work. The children should be desperate to write because they have so much to say. This usually happens around 4. They have been doing activities to prepare to write. Like, button clothes, and holding a brush, making a strong hand. The child has also been preparing the mind with thought. You cannot write until you have life experiences. Literature is an extension of life.

When the child reaches a deep appreciation for language, Montessori called this *the arrival*. We have a huge responsibility here. The child who can dress themselves is the hero of their story. Life experience must come first above all.

Order

Lecture by Rukmini Ramachandran on November 3, 2023

Humans created order from the very beginning. When any group lives together, they must create order. Nature is the ultimate creator of order. The child is unfolded by nature. Every culture has their own customs and rules that the people follow.

Routines create order and repeating order creates patterns. This allows us to predict. If you don't have these things it can be frustrating. Like with sharing a flat, if there are no rules or order it would be frustrating.

The young child lives their life in an orderly pattern. When we cannot predict the future there is chaos and that is threatening. We must keep this in mind for the younger child. We should follow the child. Don't be too strict when it comes to schedules. The child should eat when they are hungry. This teaches them to listen to their own bodies. The child does not have a reasoning mind, so the rules are just part of how they live. Calmly repeat the rules and they will feel safe and secure.

Even when the child is rushing they will roll the mat, put away the chair, etc. The first two years are important for stability and routine. It is difficult when school is the first introduction to order. We should prepare the child in advance when a change is occurring to the schedule. The sensitive period for order is from 0-6 and the peak time for order is 2 to 2.5. If you are starting to notice imagination then order must have happened earlier.

Think about order and the creation of language. The child notices patterns in language, and will start to practice language using rules, or their interpretation of the rules. Orderly societies create harmony in groups. Order is intrinsic and at the final stage becomes self-discipline.

The Child's Environment

Lecture by Rukmini Ramachandran on November 2, 2022

The number one most important thing is order. There needs to be a place for everything. Also routines. The child should be included in all activities where they are not prisoners. There should be no separation between them and the family.

- ❖ Place to Eat: They should have a place to eat that they can reach. A place that they can fetch water on their own.
- ❖ Sleep: They should have a bed in which they are not a prisoner in and can move.
- ❖ Movement/Play: They should have real supplies that are accessible to them. That look like smaller versions of what the adults use.
- ❖ Washroom: They should have a washing area to clean their hands with soap and water at their level.

Our culture says that we must create a child proof environment. We only give them plastic and teach “if you fling me, nothing will happen.” Glass cups are important. They teach very absolute lessons. If it breaks, it cannot be put back together. Toys are put in huge buckets where they cannot see anything. They are given fake plastic food to play with.

With children of this age so many things are just done TO them. We need to slow down and make time for them to work. Infancy is a time of self exploration, observation, and alone time. You cannot rush a toddler. Our children in today's culture have NO gift of time. There is no opportunity for experience. We lack patience. The greatest gift is a clean floor. The child came out of the womb because there was no more space. They need space now. *There was a separate reading provided for the exact 0-3 environment.

There is a lasting impact if there is conflict in the home in these early years. But, a child will continue to develop no matter their environment. At birth there is no will but at age 2-2.5 the child is guided by the will. Freedom is choice.

The Child in Society

Lecture by Rukmini Ramachandran, November 3, 2022

What is society? It is the views of those around you. We are part of what makes up society. Origins of the word come from the word companion. We share many things in a society: physical places, beliefs, and attitudes. Society defines our relationships. We are individual but inseparable. Families also exist in the mind and soul. Families are built to care for the child and societies from all over do this. It bonds families and brings them together to provide, protect, and be responsible for the child.

Sacrifice is necessary for a group. Even in small groups they look after one another. Concern for others is natural to humans.

During ages 3-6, the child has grown in the family. The adult is different once they have a child. A free bird traps itself to sit on an egg. A piece of your heart is walking around. The child is the center of love. The child has to belong to a wider group than their family.

In the early weeks, the child builds relationships with family. At age 1.5 or 2 they should go to school to experience social life. This must be mixed age.

In the current state of education we have a factory model to create a quick assembly line of human growth. Efficiency does not work for individuals. In the natural world, we are not the same age. The Montessori world is not an environment to learn, it is an environment to live. It takes after the “home”.

In the Casa Community how should the teachers be? Read the unpublished lectures, The Child and the Society. The teacher should be great. In a space where the children are active. The teacher does not teach and the student does not learn. They both live together.

In the 3-6 environment there is social pressure and concern for others. A great example is the snack table. The limit is to practice taking care of the well-being of others. Waiting is the most important tool. Each day they demonstrate sacrifice for others. The same is true for getting mats in the classroom. Yielding for other children.

Manners are the glue of a Montessori classroom. Grace and courtesy should be modeled for the students. Grace comes from within. Early childhood children practice this and it stays with them. There is not one for every student, you are instilling civic responsibility. The young admire older and the older admire younger. This is beautiful in the example of helping younger children tie their shoes or aprons. This helps each other's self-esteem to be capable.

Children will often do things that need to be done. They know what has to be done and will get on with it. They are so willing. Teachers should always forgive themselves. The children are forgiving and they know if you are trying your best.

Perfection is a moving target. Battle out the ego and acknowledge your mistakes. Work at always trying your best and don't get overwhelmed. Reflect at the end of the day and ask yourself what you want to work on for tomorrow. Montessori says to tie yourself to the chair. Your assistants are the children. Give yourself a bucket of kindness.

Obstacles to Development

Lecture by Rukmini Ramachandran, November 4, 2022

Deviation by nature. Montessori discovered the child early-on. She said, “the child has revealed himself to me.”

What was the nature of the discovery? There was no teacher in the early 1900’s. Maria Montessori had a mixed age group. The children were under 6 and said to be uneducateable. Montessori found that they were drawn to manipulate materials, so she provided those. From this, the true nature of the child was revealed.

The child showed concentration, perseverance, self-control, and the love of silence. Even today people say that children are in the “terrible twos” and that we must do everything for them because they have no control. We think that this is common and normal. But, we have a great misunderstanding about children. That they are crazy, naughty, running in restaurants..etc. It makes you wonder, how did such a big misunderstanding happen about young children?

We need to see the child in their natural environment. To see his natural needs. A typical couple now buys a crib (prison), the house doesn’t include them, and they are tied into every chair possible. Whatever growth is present in nature for the child, the modern world curtails the very freedom for the child.

Love is the saddest tragedy. The obstacles in the young child’s experience come from love. We want them to play with fake things when they are seeking reality. They are even sucking on a nipple that has no milk. The child is surrounded by misunderstanding. We are in the dark ages in terms of young development. All children need language, movement, and freedom. We need to love them and enable their independence. We think that what is common is normal.

Banana example: The child was working on peeling a banana and without even thinking about if the parent takes the banana and peels it for them and the baby cries for 10 minutes. They interrupted the child's work and robbed them of development.

In a study done with 18 years old, those who attended Montessori school from 3-6 years old had vastly greater self-esteem than those who attended regular school.

There are two types of deviated children:

- ❖ Screamer: that fights against every move.
- ❖ Weak personality: sneaks around protecting goods, always wines, and needs someone to sit with them.

Healthy development is self-actualization. Children need to read and write for a life of pleasure. College essays will come later. When parents arrive at your school speak to them with compassion. Build bonds of trust with them with time and steadiness. You can't always explain everything to the parents. What you can do is stand up for the child's needs and be consistent. All of this research comes from anthropological observation.

Purposeful Work

Lecture by Rukmini Ramachandran, November 4, 2022

In order to heal obstacles in our development we must work. The prepared environment is for children to work. The child is not simply sweeping or washing to clean the items, they are activities which lead to development. For children with disabilities, purposeful work will heal. Humans were born to work. A very agitated child can be calmed just by washing a table.

You never forget the children that teach you these things, all about repetitive work. Washing a shelf over and over and over, feeling so good.

When the children break the rules calming tell them what is not acceptable, always holding the boundary. You can tell them in a calm voice, “come and sit next to me.” Keep the children secure in the boundaries so that they may taste the freedom and happiness of work. The deviated child needs the path to concentration more than ever. Work is the grounding point. If you look to the child that is not there yet, they are the “new” teacher. Montessori teachers work for greater world peace. We are servants of the soul.

In all situations, boundaries must be consistent and everyone must feel safe. An example could be a student that hits others at school.

*See Montessori’s lectures in India, 1948 for further reading.

Normalization

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 7, 2022

This is a difficult concept to speak with parents about. They get upset if you say anything like, “your child is not yet normalized.” Maria Montessori said, “Normalization is a first plane phenomena. It’s when it has happened that’s when education can begin.” It is the cooperation of thoughts, words, actions, and being able to judge oneself. Now, 40 years later, it is the single most important component of our work.

Children were thought to be untruthful, over imaginative, and some of these assumptions are still true today. Instead of jumping to conclusions, Maria Montessori just started to observe the children in their natural environments all over the world. All around the world there is a similar thread in all children.

Normality is really following nature as the law, as it was intended. Henry Fabre said that children must be in their nature to develop. He was an etomologist who did all of his observations in the field. Montessori was inspired by him. Energy can be wasted if it is not allowed to follow its natural course.

4 Characteristics of Normalization: (they must all be present)

1. Love of work
2. Concentration
3. Self-Discipline
4. Sociability

In turn, normalized children:

1. Have spontaneous discipline
2. Happy and continuous work
3. Social

4. Empathy

Choice has to be present for the love of work. Concentration appears when a group of children become absorbed in the work.

Normalization occurs through concentration on a piece of work. Each child should be presented with something different. Children need rest. Do not intervene always. Idleness and rest are different. A child loves to complete a cycle of work and that is when fulfillment happens. If there is not rest then inner formation may be lacking.

With self-discipline, when you make a commitment you must stay with it. When you change so frequently stamina is lost. The child must stick with their choice. Perseverance is another trait after concentration. All children have this power. They demonstrate sociability with patience, by waiting their turn, respect for others, and harmonious working relationships. Children must respect the work of others because they will meet this reality in their daily experience. Everyone does not have one of everything.

Example: the children's house in Chennai had one book. The children held it with such reverence.

A human response is to turn to others. You are happy and want to help others. Normalization will happen with purposeful work. In the first plane, normalization is greater than academics. There should be security and confidence in the environment. Also, order. Energy is wasted in disorder. When children are independent, we leave them alone. The activity should arouse enough interest to engage the whole personality.

The children must have freedom of choice. From this freedom, he will engage in work which will support his development of bringing the impulses under control, and hence, strengthening the will.

Mind - Movement - Will with Conscious Choice - Repetition - Concentration

Normalization is a process which needs sustaining. But these qualities stay with us for life. You are not doomed if this doesn't happen for you, but life will come more naturally. Without the will, their inner drive is very hard to get going. This impacts the whole future. The materials are made for development. Exploration and manipulation helps everyone in the right direction. After all, that's how Montessori began her work. You have to observe and try different strategies to help each individual.

When communicating with parents you have to make it clear that it is not just the school that raises the child. Parent education teaches parents how to support their children.

Love of work can open the mind.

The Child at the Age of Six

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 7, 2022

This child is in the children's house and moving up. They are prepared in numerous ways. They are pursuing their interests and they are curious learners. Montessori children come so excited, but those from traditional schools seem to lose interest. Our task is to nourish the sense of wonder.

This child has independent caring for oneself and the environment. As well as coordination of movement, grace and courtesy, and opportunity for language. They are on their way toward abstraction. Early sensorial experiences develop into the abstract. They are hungry for words and it is a sensitive period for language.

Margaret Stevenson, who was appointed by Mario Montessori, started a Montessori institute in the states. She came up with more complex reading and writing examples for children. They delight in the complications of words and stories. They are offered opportunities for written language. Introduction to parts of speech, the function of words, rules of speech, and grammar. Language acquired before 6 years old will stay with them for life.

There are lovely materials in their environment.

- ❖ Contrasting trays of clay and water with a knife to cut the clay.
- ❖ Static geography of how the world looks now
- ❖ They have going outs
- ❖ Nomenclature that corresponds to the geography
- ❖ Geometry is part of the environment, they are observing unconsciously
- ❖ Everyday experience to the children like measuring, time, weight
- ❖ Matching symbols to quantities
- ❖ Decimals and fractions

❖ Presented with big problems in math if they know the process

There are no obstacles against math in a Montessori classroom. We should intrigue and evoke curiosity so that children may work on their own. They are starting to seek peers to work with. They are moving into a more social organization.

If the child at 6 has lived through 0 to 6 in a Montessori environment then they can be responsible for their behavior and work independently. They have command of language and expression. They can differentiate.

Second Plane of Development

Theory

Characteristics of the Second Plane

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 8, 2022

The Second Plane of development spans from 6 to 12 years old. The child has changes in needs and potentialities. We can aid once we know where they are going. The second plane has sensitivities and not sensitive periods.

This is a calm plane and is not divided, although some environments can be divided by age. The advantage to having a combined environment is that the children experience many kinds of work. As an adult you have to distinguish the needs of a 6 year old and a 12 year old. If you separate the environment between 6 to 9 and 9-12 it is nice for the students to go through the learning cycle and be the youngest, then the oldest.

This plane is a healthy time of development. Children have a lot of energy and are headed towards the outside world. They want to understand all of the questions and are hungry for culture.

- ❖ First Plane: “Help me to do it by myself.”
- ❖ Second Plane: “Help me to think for myself.”

There is enormous potential for work and when given the choice, they will choose great work. Elementary students like to put words to actions. They practice writing exact instructions and then trying to follow the instructions and see if it worked.

Don't underestimate their capacity for great work. Don't think, “this will be too hard.” Present to them from all different subject areas. This group learns more easily than adolescents because it is a calm plane. Health and strength are increased from the first plane to second plane, but in the third plane the energy is taken for things like immense physical growth.

The intellect and the abstract are organized which creates the reasoning mind. But the first plane can also reason very practically. Abstractions are based on sensorial experiences done in the first plane. They manipulate ideas and want to know facts and definitions of everything. Who? What? Where? When? Why? How? They come with many questions and it can be so tiring. They need to ask questions for their high-powered reasoning.

Another sensitivity that they have is for *imagination*. The first plane explores through their senses and the second plane through imagination. Knowledge has possibilities for becoming lifelong learners. There is always more knowledge. We don't want them to think they are finished learning. Theories exist first in your imagination. Anticipatory imagination is looking forward to the future. Adolescents are very interested in this.

Students ages 6-12 have the entire universe as a reality. They have a world understanding and what to know how it affects the life and behavior of humanity. The physical environment is not so important but it should still be ordered. Cosmic education is the education plan for the second plane.

Students in the second plane demonstrate moral independence, justice, compassion, and are interested in good and evil. They can be very frank and honest and fairness is very important to them. They are social beings and choose group work. You do not want to isolate them. They naturally start to have division of labor and leaders emerge.

They write in work journals to plan their time and activities. The question is, "What have you chosen for yourself today?" Help them go through their work journals and label their time. Don't make judgments, just help them write what they determine. Help them realize that they are capable of a high work capacity. Have them reflect at the end of the day. If there is a slow work pattern, have them work over the weekend. They need to have resolution, commitment, and finish things.

They want to spend their time with their peers. They like to organize groups and talk about secret languages. They demonstrate “herd instinct.” They organize blind votes and practical life. They take care of shopping, thank you notes, and fundraising. They plan going outs in the community and practice grace and courtesy. If you notice manipulation of other students you can say something like, “Now we know what you like, let’s see what everyone else would like.”

Going Out

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 8, 2022

The students should be given purposeful activities. Don't give them the idea that all knowledge is in the classroom. Students today are deprived of purposeful activities. They are driven everywhere, but they should walk. Going out in the community prepares the spiritual being. The children are physically independent at this time and they have a tendency for exploring and orientating to the wider society. They make judgments about what is right and wrong. They must also see the world by observing nature and establishing social relationships in the environment.

There are many considerations when planning going outs in your community. They gain this independence thanks to their own effort. They go out without an adult and in a group. Montessori says these conditions permit social experiences. It's nice for them to encounter all types of people and the community will start to recognize them.

Cosmic Fables and Key Lessons

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 8, 2022

The needs and psychological characteristics of second plane children include hero worship, interest in the extraordinary, interest in morality, and opportunities for great work. The central education plan for the second plane are the Cosmic Fables or Great Stories. The students are hungry for knowledge and understanding about the greater world. These stories feed the children's imaginations and give them a totality about the universe. Five stories are given very early and the sixth stands on its own and comes much later.

These stories are meant to open up a door and stimulate interest. They rely on imagination and move from whole to detail to whole picture again. Before the presentation, there is a psychological piece to grab their attention. They are told in a dramatic way with rich and precise language, personification, and they portray mystery but they are all true stories. Afterwards, they are set to rest and ponder a little. We do not ask anything of them afterwards related to work. These presentations just require listening and enjoying. This leads to a lot of scientific exploration and you go where the children need to go.

Key Lessons:

In the great story presentations, there is only so much information presented to help the child see the whole picture. Before they go on their own to explore, they need key lessons. The purpose of these lessons is to remove obstacles from the child's path. For going out the children may be given lessons on:

- ❖ What to look for
- ❖ How to organize their outing
- ❖ How to be safe

Some lessons might be technical (techniques that help them reach their aim in the shortest time possible)

- ❖ Writing
- ❖ Art
- ❖ Skill

There are other key lessons that also need to be mastered in order to continue exploration:

- ❖ Mathematics
- ❖ Geometry
- ❖ Language
- ❖ Music

Each child must be observed in order to know which key lesson is needed. Be careful to provide only what is necessary in the environment. Everything should be purposeful and no ‘busy work’ should be present. Cosmic lessons are meant to inspire and key lessons teach the fundamentals and the motions. Some lessons could also be given that are not key lessons but that interest or supplement the child’s skills.

Classification and Nomenclature:

These key lessons support the opportunity for students to reason on their own. It provides an analysis of characteristics. It is presented to them in folders. The blank space exists to show them that there is always more to learn and explore. We always study the etymology of words. The nomenclature is very rich in the environment. It helps to express themselves precisely. The aim is to provide them with exact terminology and root of the word, leading to the reading of books.

It also helps them acquire the confidence and courage to enter a new subject area. It helps them piece things together and the world becomes more familiar. Understanding helps take away fear and we want fearless students.

Freedom and Discipline

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 9, 2022

Cosmic Education prepares the child for this responsibility. The classroom is mixed ages, there are a limited number of materials, and it is all in order.

Freedom goes with a different component in each environment:

- ❖ First Plane: Freedom and Discipline
- ❖ Second Plane: Freedom and Responsibility
- ❖ Third Plane: Freedom and Duty has been a suggestion; but it is not clearly defined.

There are many traditional views of freedom. It is thought to have no boundaries and to be chaotic. But, freedom is really the odder to have or do something, not the freedom from something. Freedom of choice is traditionally thought of as a reward. But freedom in Montessori is quite different.

Freedom is the capacity to choose when faced with choice and it is based on knowledge. Maria Montessori said that *“The emphasis on freedom is for the development of individuality. Emphasis on discipline is for society and the individual.”*

It's not about being led but about the freedom to follow. We are looking for discipline that is an active choice. A child who freely chooses activities and follows through to completion. Freedom of choice in adolescents is spoken about more freely because also it is in an environment where feedback is given immediately. This type of freedom is not a democratic system.

Having a beautiful environment is not enough. There needs to be a balance between freedom and discipline. The child has an inner guide and spontaneous discipline. Independence and ownership of the environment is very important.

Adolescents don't choose activities in the same way that the first and second plane do. As adults we try to help children organize so that they don't have to be patient. The erasers were removed from the environment and the writing skills went up! Some look at bathroom breaks as a "work decline." But what do we mean by work? He may have been doing work in the bathroom.

An adult can ask a child to give them a presentation and the child can exercise their will by saying yes or no. They usually have mutual respect for time. They cannot join midway because they made a choice. With choice, comes commitment. It's important that all of the adults in the environment are consistent. You can't allow something one day, and not on the other.

The children are allowed to walk around different environments and they will realize if they are in the wrong environment. This is the open door policy that Montessori talks about in her writings.

Freedom of Movement:

The older students love helping and they enjoy a mutual exchange of spiritual energy. Mixed age is a part of the communities to remind that the development is at a different pace. In math, if you are always the one who does not understand, you will always feel this way. It's very different for children to make choices if they have to rely on an adult.

Classroom environments had the "circle of choice" which was a material that Jenny Hoglund made. Students color in areas that represent subject areas that they have studied. Like botony, language, math...etc., The circle is never complete.

The children are allowed to socially interact and this is what gives birth to grace and courtesy. The guide does not need to whisper in the environment, this is not natural. The children get very confused if an activity is available one day but not the other.

The children should have freedom to reflect. Reflection is important and we may see that they are just sitting. They don't always have to always look busy; the mind can still be busy. Not providing enough freedom will not lead to discipline. Freedom is not a gift, it is a conquest. They need to work at it and the adults need to support it. Children are born with an inner discipline and energy. We must trust in the children's abilities. Adults today forget to do this.

Cosmic Education

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 9, 2022

We give students stories so that they can imagine themselves in the whole picture of the universe. It helps them to acquire a sense of the world and a sense of meaning. It also helps them to feel a sense of security and belonging. History will aid moral development through reflection of the cosmic plan and the consequences of their choices. This is done through the work of study called Cosmic Education.

Cosmic education is a cosmic view of the world and history is the core. History orients us, and children use history in order to understand where we are now in order to see where we might go in the future. There are three keys to history: migration, time and fundamental human needs.

The cosmic fables open up each subject area. The subjects must be correlated and as teachers we need to be aware of the interdependence. The child's nature is to understand everything is connected. The stories answer why and how questions, like the story of Evolutionary Succession.

The global view of the universe needs to be presented in an ecological way. Each individual has its own cosmic task. *The Story of Human Beings* is respected and admired. Every subject can be related to human beings. *The Story of the Ox and The House* explores the alphabet and language. As well as the natural and supernatural. *The Story of Numbers* involves math. The children usually love math. There are no abstractions, no manipulations of the formulas. It is about different systems of numeration. The decimal system is the reference point. Practical life also presents problems to be solved. Seeing the differences in others creates toleration. *The Story of The Great River* discusses the human body and how society functions. There is an image to display solidarity.

The purpose of cosmic education is to encompass totality and give a framework for life and security. The purpose is to ignite flames of further exploration. There is hero worship of the

human. It gives the children prosperity for great work. Guides should present until an interest is taken. The stories sew many seeds. They give an orientation and a guide for life. It's a special approach to history and makes the child aware of time passing. There are three keys to history: time, migration, and fundamental needs. Children learn the universe as a community of subjects. Children are included in this and acquire a historical identity. We realize that our roots are in the past, if we lose this context then we will be lost. These stories help them orient themselves to time and space. They are an extension of love. All humans have the same needs and human achievements are a witness to humanity.

Natural resources help satisfy our needs. These stories help bring forth the value of each individual. They help create admiration and gratitude for others. The feelings of right and wrong can be understood on a grander scale. It helps them see that ordinary humans are the heroes through the work that they did before us.

Morality and Cosmic Education

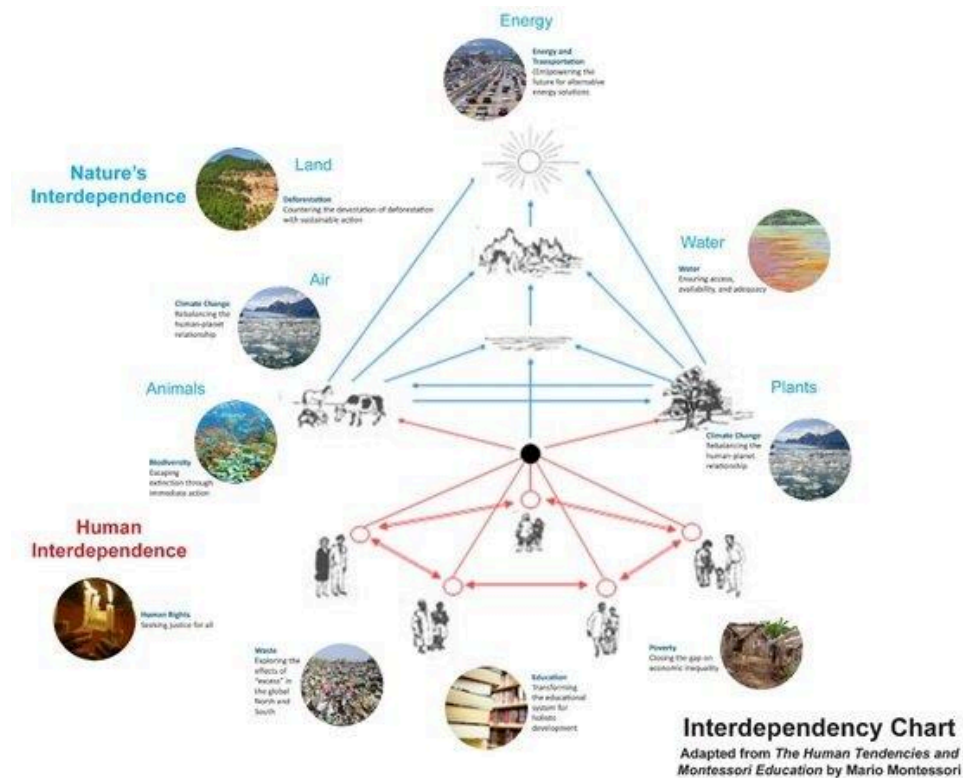
Another purpose of cosmic education is for a better world, for world peace. The author Rachel Carson said that the child's view of the world is pure. The future of the earth is dependent upon individual choice. The first plane child focuses on functional independence, while the second plan child focuses on moral independence. Children are born with moral forces. They must be nourished. Moral development comes from sharing and building connections between groups and how the groups learn to work together. We have to look at the child as an essential instrument of history for mankind. When you greet them you're saying, "you are my promise and hope." They are the cement of the future.

Why do we study cosmic education? So that children have a chance to ponder over what it means to be human. The children learn that values are behind all decisions. Through the lens of history, the child sees how they can now make a difference. The book of virtues is a compilation of poems and literature that you can show the children. You can read excerpts from the book to them. You're not preaching virtues here, but telling stories of characters who could inspire.

Chart of Interdependence

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on November 11, 2022

Mario Montessori's Chart of Interdependence is an unconscious exchange of services. It involves many cosmic agents like the sun, rocks, water, plants, air, animals, and people. It represents the whole of cosmic education. We should view this from a child's perspective, because sometimes it can be very different if we view it from an adult's perspective. Everyone has their own little sphere but we are all under the great supranature.



Humans came to transform the earth, but it could not be done alone. It requires the whole of humanity. The arrows depicted are those of dependency. In the third plane, adolescents will live

this idea more consciously. The chart has an overlay with red dots that fits over top of it. It is supposed to indicate areas where humans have transformed the earth in big ways.

Story of The Great River (personal response)

Presented by Jenny Höglund on November 11, 2022

The story of *The Great River* is presented to the children last out of the six great stories. Jenny read this story to us and I had never heard or read about it before which was really nice. I listened to the story for the very first time and at the end of the story I was quite surprised. The full title is, “*The Country or Nation of the Great River*”. The story begins by explaining a ‘marvelous nation’ where the inhabitants are hidden from sight but are all working together to achieve so much. The story goes on to explain all of the different departments in the country that are working together, how they depend on each other, and what they do for the overall country. Towards the end of the story we find out that the ‘*Great River*’ is the human body, “where all the inhabitants work and live in harmony.” I thought this story was such a beautiful metaphor, I really loved it. The way Jenny read the story also had a lot to do with how interested I was in the country that she was describing. Then, towards the end of the story it is even more magical when she said, “Can you feel the great river that is flowing through each of us right now? Can you feel its pulse?” The story ends with a question to the children, “Would you like to find out more about the human body?” What a lovely story to incite appreciation and excitement for our own bodies and the incredible things that they do for us each day.

Silent Journey (handwritten personal response included)

Ribbon Exercise (personal response)

After we took part in the Silent Journey through the first and second plane classrooms, we were asked to choose a material. After we all had a material, we sat in a circle and set our materials out in front of us. We were then asked to use colored ribbons to connect our material with those of other subject areas that were related to our own, and to the earth. The connections were endless and we actually ran out of ribbon in some areas. This exercise gave us a visual representation of how all of the subject areas that we study are connected to one cosmic center. It was a really beautiful representation seeing how everything was physically connected through the colorful ribbons. The interconnectedness was very apparent.

“You cannot understand biology without understanding chemistry or physics, and you cannot study life without its environment, which brings us geography.” *Camillo Grazzini in Cosmic Education at the Elementary Level and the Role of Materials*

Third Plane of Development

Theory

Reforms Related to the Vital Needs of the Adolescent

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on June 26, 2023

It was clear to Maria Montessori, and some others, that reforms were needed in secondary teaching. It was not only an education problem, but also a human and social problem. She thought that the problems of the future could be solved if we aid the child in education. She saw the child as the constructor of tomorrow's man.

Montessori was a psychologist, Doctor, anthropologist, and translator. She was interested in children and worked with children with special needs. She found that the children with special needs were not stimulated enough, but when she gave them things to manipulate they changed. These were the children that society thought were not able to go to school. Working with children in the first plane makes a huge impact. Elementary students are already formed.

Montessori's main goal was human solidarity. She believed that education must change. The current system provided very little for personality and social life. It should give value to the human personality. Education and peace go together. Life and education are both continuums.

There is a rebirth during the third plane, into a social being. Secondary school is a gateway to the personality and social organization. The adolescents should never feel like they can't do the work and there should be enough work for everyone that fits them. They cannot have a fixed program, but something more flexible with the adolescent at the center. There needs to be social experience and independence. They need activities to enhance themselves and valorization is huge.

The structure of the prepared environment provides freedom. The prepared adult also plays a big role. Work is very different to Montessori. It should be the backbone of everything we do. Get the framework clear and then you can plan the structure.

Social Experience

We need to build the right sort of environment. Most adolescents aren't able to have social experience because there's not enough free time. We are born to move and work.

We as humans are not wired to sit and read. It's very challenging for us. It's the absolute wrong approach to learn. It has to be concrete experiences. The same is true for all ages. We absorb through our body and movement.

Montessori argues that work is necessary for self-construction. Work is also a human tendency. It's a cosmic task to work, you play a role in a bigger picture. They are seeking social and economic independence. Vocation has to do with the search for identity and analyzing one's objectives in life. What is there for me? It is responding to what life asks of you.

The third plane presents sensitive periods for personal dignity and justice. Montessori speaks of the fourth plane and attitudes of power. The physical environment plays a big role in this and she names it "Erdkinder," which means the land children. Never underestimate the influence of the first and second plane. What happens in the third plane, is dependent on what happened in the previous planes. The entire school needs to be in cohesion. Montessori says that the third plane has to be prepared for by the first and second planes.

Social development is taking pleasure in cooking and serving snack for the community. How can we help maintain this mindset of doing and sharing with others? Elementary students plan going outs. But in the third plane, it is not just about making and selling things to the parents. It's about working to sustain oneself. They are working to develop themselves so that they can become agents for a better world.

We want to do a lot for our students and children. There is an interdependence and that is separate from independence. There is a mutual dependency but the parents may not be so dependent on the children. We must never substitute their work for our work.

It's not just about having a special lifestyle at school, and then going home to a completely different environment. If they don't put in the effort, life will not go on for them. It has to be their environment. Most things on the Montessori Rydet campus have been donated second-hand. We don't want them to think that the work is our responsibility. When it is their decision about all these little things, they become bonding experiences for them. There was an example about getting a piano to the farm. There were many challenges that they had to figure out and it took all day. You don't need to make everything perfect for them.

You cannot have an environment that is too big. They make a lot of phone calls to people in the community. It's nice for them to get to know neighbors and trade work with them. There should be many opportunities for real situations that need solving. They should have opportunities to work with many different people. Jenny has never asked a student in an environment, "x who would you like to work with today?" It is always something like, "x and x, come along and you can..."

Freedom in the adolescent community is freedom to choose as a community. They are extremely loyal and gracious when it comes to eating food that others have cooked. People rarely say no to being served. The community practices grace and courtesy when they share food. They are gracious and there is so much value in that.

Preparation for the Third Plane

The Montessori approach was the result of a lot of work and methodology. Education should help the child develop naturally. The child has an inner teacher. Each plane has its own developmental task. The development of the child should be at the center. The environment helps this development and through interaction with the environment, the child learns.

The Prepared Environment

The prepared environment is filled with objects, experiences, materials, and situations that allow the children to be free. *When children say, "there is nothing for me to do," we should hear, "there is nothing worth doing here."* There must not be a challenge or engagement in the

environment. If there are abundant resources, they will not care for things. The environment should prepare for further learning. Children come with different skills, so we cannot think there is only one way to do things. Interests need to be determined on part by the child or adolescent. It cannot just be the effort of the teacher. If you can translate their interests into experiences this will serve them best. They'll do the work either way but nothing will happen intrinsically.

Considerations for Elementary Guides

Time management is important in the elementary. Also the ability to work without supervision. Cleaning up after yourself is a practice that starts very early in the Montessori environment and something that should be reinforced at home. There's an emotional connection as a parent so you have to work for their practical work independence. Parents tend to do too much for their children, out of love.

Order

If a second plane child has been through proper order in the first plane, it is within them. Adolescence is a late age to experience order for the first time. Adolescence will speak up for one another. They don't want to let their community down, so it's best for them to receive peer feedback on corrections over feedback from their guide.

Simply choosing research topics is not the level of choice they need. They've already done this in the elementary. They need to feel connected and truly needed and depended on within the community. What are they in charge of and how much ownership do they have? This helps the community function well.

The Third Plane of Development

Lecture by Jenny Höglund on June 27, 2023

The third plane of development spans from 12 to 18 years old. Around the age of 12, Montessori says that it's the birth of the *new social being*. Leaving the two planes of childhood and entering the two planes of adulthood.

“We can establish a parallel between childhood and the insect...” Maria Montessori quote

Needs

The child has come with 12 years of experience and we hope they have received proper first and second plane preparation. Maria Montessori said, “We preserve the future by protecting the present.” Each plane of development needs to be carefully and quickly considered in the present, or we'll miss the opportunity. The third plane is a rebirth of a different social man. The third plane is a plane of creation and is parallel with the first plane. This is a time of a lot of changes. It is a period of transformation and hormones. The adolescent needs to be protected. These changes make them fragile and delicate.

“Because of the rapid development and changes the physical organism must go through...”
Maria Montessori quote.

The third plane revolves around moving from the immediate family to joining society. They practice materialized abstraction. When the adolescents make changes in their environment, it leads to them to being more empowered to make changes. They must demonstrate environmentalism in their own environment before they understand it on a grander scale. They must practice in the concrete world first. Don't push the adult world onto them too soon. It starts with how you live your daily life.

The developmental task of the adolescent is to participate in the workings of society and to do real adult work.

Physical Characteristics

There are three types of characteristics across all planes: physical, psychological, and social.

Physical Characteristics can be divided into three change areas:

Preparation (12-14)

Blooming (14-16)

Perfection (16-18)

In a newborn, there is so much happening right away and rapidly. There is a complete change of the individual. It takes a lot of energy and the body concentrates much of its energy on these physical changes.

Fatigue: They're night owls but need a lot of sleep. They easily tire.

Nutrition: They do not eat properly if left to their own devices.

Exercise: In the 1930's, Maria Montessori wrote that they spent too much time sitting still.

Illness: Their bodies are more prone to illness and this is the time that many illnesses originate.

They need to be connected to the land, to eat nourishing food, strengthen the body and work on their coordination.

Psychological Characteristics

This is a critical age for doubts, hesitations, and violent emotions. There is a decrease in intellectual capacity. Intellectually, they seem weaker because of the physical changes. They've lost their fondness for study compared to elementary children.

Variety of Work

They have manual work, academic work, and all aspects of real adult work. They need to work within the context of becoming an adult with something that they can relate to. Then they will work. The young adolescent is not oriented to who he is in relation to his environment. We say things like, “you know better,” but then we also treat them like a child, so they feel confused about whether they belong or not. They have great power but they don’t know where to use it.

Sensitivities

The adolescent needs work and experiences that can satisfy his sensitivities in the third plane. They are: *personal dignity* (the opportunity to feel capable), and *justice* (everyone may not get exactly the same, but everyone should get what they need). They are extremely sensitive to what they perceive as criticism. They are seeking equality with their peers and there is always something to worry about. They’re very critical, analytical, they worry about appearances, status, both financial and social. It is important that we don’t judge the adolescent. They are not sure of their identity, so the environment should support this. They can act impulsively but there is also a shyness. It is a period of meditation and contemplation, so they sometimes seek solitude. They imagine a future that could be theirs and dream of a grander life. They don’t know anything about this new life, but they want to prove themselves. *It is important that they are not treated as children.*

Independencies

Independencies for the adolescent are economic and social independence. Overall, the adolescent should be taken away from his family and join an environment that has been prepared for him and his needs. As much independence in life as possible are the optimal conditions.

Social Characteristics

The adolescent is a newborn and they want to be away from their families. Development and nature will reach their goals if they remove themselves from their families. They need an environment where they are included in life. *Often adolescents are excluded from social life.*

This brings up a dinner party example from Joseph Allen who was giving a lecture in the states. Children used to be a part of dinner parties and now it has evolved to them not even being expected at dinner. Parents are also doing too much for their adolescents. They don't yet know their destiny belongs to two families: the one that they know, and their own future family.

They need to participate in life in a larger environment and learn what it takes to sustain a community. Neuroscientist Steven J. talks about how parents have a big influence on their children, but in adolescence it is zero percent. Young people's primary attachment is with their peer groups. There's a new experience which is that work requires collaboration, discipline, and natural consequences.

Puberty is one of the most complex and critical periods. They should be treated with dignity, careful attention, the same attention that we give the first plane child. If they are having difficulties, they have the opportunity to be mended through work. They need to move away from home because you have a "defined role" at home and your family has preconceived notions about you. They need to be free to become their own individuals.

Production and Exchange

This is not just about earning money. *It has social and moral underpinnings.* They need to feel that they are capable and that they can manage things. Maria Montessori says that they should manage land, a store, and a guesthouse.

It is time for them to experience people in the environment. When they have realistic role models around them they think, "I could be like this person." They ponder on what it means to be human and what guides your choices. They should also have opportunities for self-expression like art, music, dance, and writing. We want to set up a framework in which they can orient themselves in society and in their community.

At the end of the third plane, adolescents are usually pushed to make choices about work and college. We hope that they have some kind of a realistic idea of who they are and what they are

capable of. Being comfortable and happy in the third plane is critical, as the third plane is a critical stage for development and what we do matters. It is a sensitive period for personal dignity and justice. The environment gives them the orientation they need, to go into the unprepared world.

Human Tendencies Manifested in The Third Plane

Lecture by Leslie Ann Patrick on June 27, 2023

How can we serve these young people? Step back and realize what nature has given them. It's not about us, we need to collaborate with them

We should reflect on human tendencies and ask how we can use them to help guide adolescents? We should go back to Mario's booklet on human tendencies and remind ourselves of the great gifts that the adolescents have.

What are human tendencies? They are the system of natural inner guides which are unique to humans and aid in human development. They are universal, observable, unchangeable. They are verbs, alive, active, and hereditary. It urges us to act upon the environment. If these tendencies are obstructed this is when deviations will appear. We should see, recognize, and support human tendencies.

Order is not a human tendency, but without order, human tendencies cannot function. We don't want them in physical or social chaos. If we have order in the environment than human tendencies can flourish. Everything has a specific place and order is necessary for the tendencies to function in an optimal way.

Orientation: Finding points of reference. The physical environment, people questions, people, questions, boundaries, spiritual boundaries; this allows us to feel secure and safe and then we can explore. The brain and body is changing so much. They are unsure of who they want to be and what the expectations are. We can help them do this with consistency, meetings...etc. It cannot be all at once. They need orientations right before the task. Example: revisiting chicken care instructions right before their chicken care date, orient the group right before math seminar so that they can feel safe to explore. They also need to orient themselves to real life consequences.

Explore: Adolescents are constantly exploring all types of relationships. What are they good at? How do you ask for help? They gain moral development through relationships. They explore their own value systems: physically, mentally, socially, creatively. We can support them through dialogue. It requires the adult to be open. They explore work and their capabilities. They explore the limits and boundaries of their communities.

Observe: Adolescents use all senses while observing. Example: visiting veterinarian: the adolescents were more interested in the vet than in the sick pig. They will observe everything you do and imitate you. They are very analytical and are always watching and listening to you. You have to be honest and model what you ask of them.

Abstract: Humans draw the abstract from concrete experiences. This becomes the root of all creative ideas in the future. These are not received by lectures from adults or by math problems; it is received by work with their own hands. Through relationships, they experience kindness, compassion...etc. Empathy is very difficult to abstract. It takes metacognition that has not yet set in for the young adolescent. They can imagine work that can happen in the environment.

Imagination: new ideas, new solutions, different realities. Imagination is a second plane sensitivity. Instead of cosmic education, they are now imagining how they fit into the universe. We don't want them to feel like, "no, that is too difficult." The adults should always be learning and figuring things out with the adolescent. "You get nowhere without dreams." Imagination can be related to empathy, to really understand someone's situation. Imagination is necessary for art and self-expression.

Active, manipulate, and work: The work of the adult is to build supranature. While they are doing this work, they are constructing their unique personality. They learn through doing the work not from sitting still. Adolescents come to discover themselves when exposed to many different activities and subject areas. They work in many different roles and areas. They draw on tendencies to help them to concentrate and be exact. It helps in refinement. It's our job to get to know them and be able to offer them the right kind of work. Which parts of the environment are

good for them today? They want to know the why of the work. They need to work on themselves to be a part of the community. It's important for them to see that their work is a contribution to the community. Margaret Stephenson says *work is necessary for sanity*.

Exactness: repetition, understanding. They have a lot of opportunities for this tendency. This happens in practical work and also in social expectations. We want to set the adolescent up for success. This doesn't mean doing it for them, but we do not want them to build something that falls down the next day. It's important for them to be accepted into the group, to know expectations, and have opportunities for practice.

Calculate: This describes opportunities for accurate planning and problem solving. There is a lot of room for mathematics. Many aspects of adult life require calculations and decision making. Montessori talks a lot about repetition. We have to practice and make mistakes knowing that we have a need for exactness. They need to have time to repeat. In order to build up repetition, there has to be multiple opportunities for the same activity. For example: if you have cooking once every six weeks, how will they have ample opportunity to repeat? They like to repetitively mimic each other or do something over and over that they enjoy. If you are regularly in the kitchen, they have the opportunity to work on another human tendency, the tendency to perfect oneself.

Perfect Oneself: We are not looking for perfect humans here. How can you do your best and reach your potential? Self-image is huge and we must be very sensitive. Young people feel so much pressure, especially with how they look. How can we help direct their need to perfect oneself? Students like to perfect one's favorite hobbies like music and calligraphy. Practicing and role-playing for farmers markets.

Control: Master our physical bodies and movement We as adults have these same tendencies. Social behavior, language, impulses. We are being challenged through technology. We want to help them to function as independent individuals. How can we help adolescents control their impulses? We have to help protect them from things which they cannot protect themselves from (like cell phones) until they develop the adult will. They are under so much peer pressure. They

have the tendency to control themselves but that tendency gets buried with so many distractions. They love to play. We have to support their learning to control. They learn to control their emotions when living with each other. They also practice control by having less resources.

Associate: We all want social contact with other people. “One single human race.” Example: there is a culture where the greeting means, “hello to my other self.” The human has always been part of a social group. We don’t learn in isolation. We have a need to belong. From birth, humans belong starting with their mother’s arms. The worst thing you can do for an adolescent is to send them off to work alone. The social experience has to be a part of every environment.

Communicate: Communication is how we pass on information but it is way more than just words. We need to communicate a part of ourselves to another person. It is a journey of self discovery. Dialogue is a great way to support this tendency. Also, through art, drama, music, dance. They also use nonverbal communication.

Repeat: They like to repeat experiences. They repeat words, language.

Mathematical Mind: Margaret Stephenson talks about how we are all born with a mathematical mind. They calculate who will do what in certain tasks. A lot of planning and estimating.

You cannot separate the human tendencies. They are all connected. They are all positive and aids to life. We can provide experiences for the human tendencies to flourish. Take a look at your own human tendencies. What are you like? We also have tendencies at play when we work with them. We present opportunities for them, so that their own inner teacher can guide them.

The Prepared Environment

Leslie Ann Patrick, June 28, 2023

The prepared environment for adolescents includes the physical, social, indoor, and outdoor environments. The environment should offer experiences that support the adolescent's human tendencies, sensitivities, and their developmental task. It is important to understand the psychology of the adolescent in order to honor the components mentioned above. Keep revisiting the psychology of adolescents with your colleagues. Adolescents need the right ambiance and nurture. If we want them to become successful contributors then they need to feel safe, loved, nurtured, respected, and dignified.

Physical Environment

If we are talking about wanting the adolescent's to own their environment, we must allow them to prepare for it. Have open conversations with parents about what "Work and Study" means. We can ask ourselves, "are there opportunities here for them to do things?" Put aside what you think would be good; you have to be ready for them to accept or reject your suggestion. Always hold in your head Montessori's vision. Also, let them read what Montessori has written. Remember to be patient with them, some sewn seeds may manifest in the fourth plane. *Montessori says, "You have to stop thinking of yourself as a school, and yourself as a teacher. It is a school of experience in the elements of social life."* This is what we are preparing the environment for.

It has to be a residential community with intellectual studies. They like learning; they just need to study in a different way. Ask yourself, "How do we have freedom of choice?" If it's not free choice, then it is free labor. It is not what the adults want when they want it, it is a community. Adolescents are the future stewards of this planet. The goal of adolescence is to balance the natural and manmade world. We need to make sure that the adolescent's physical bodies are well and taken care of. Ask yourself, "How does the environment support a healthy lifestyle?" A kitchen and food preparation is essential. As well as standards of personal and communal hygiene. They should also receive essential knowledge in taking care of the house: unclogging sinks, wiring a

plug, painting...etc. There should also be time to work on the land. The adolescents should have their hands in the soil somehow.

Compromises don't work in Montessori. They should have fresh organic food, work with animals. They should work on the land to understand science and the history of the human story. The land provides a limitless field for science and history of civilization. We need to take responsibility for the quality and conservation of resources. The land provides the opportunity for self-construction.

Their work cannot be blocked. You have to be prepared to give them freedom of the land. Montessori talks about work in the country and opportunities to build relationships with neighbors. It is part of the prepared social environment to share food with neighbors. We should encourage them to work with tools and machinery. It enables them to learn how to use technology in an appropriate way. Montessori talks about *sopranatura*, or super nature. A garden is all nature, but once we have manipulated it, it is *supernature*.

Maria Montessori talks about the "*Museum of Machinery*," where we continue to use old machines throughout the environment. This provides the adolescents with concrete experiences of the evolution of inventions. The study of the downsides of agriculture provide a great moral study.

Self-expression includes things like a workshop where students can do different art forms like pottery, drawing, painting, sculpting, and creating. They should also have a shop to sell their goods. Maria Montessori uses the word "*bodega*," where people visit to see things that the adolescents have created.

There should be a hotel onsite that the students run. Montessori calls this the, "Rural Children's Hostel." Parents and guests can come for a short stay, and students offer hospitality.

Social Environment

Older students are permitted to leave the residential environment sometimes. They may go to the local University or city centers to work. The city center is a wonderful prepared environment for

the 16 to 18-year-old. The key roles in the residential environment are the house parents and the farm manager. *When adolescents are in the right environment, you don't see their fragility, you see their strength.* The house parent has to treat each individual differently. There are many different roles in the environment. The Appendix B in Childhood to Adolescence goes through all of the different roles.

Freedom, discipline, and responsibility are all connected. There should be mixed ages and personalities. Ask yourself, “where are there opportunities for each adolescent to shine?” The beauty of control and error on the farm is that you *see it right away*. There is immediate biofeedback. Residential life provides the opportunity for ongoing work to be resolved.

**It is not about a set curriculum or schedule.*

When you draw on the garden, the shop, the hotel, etc., these experiences will prepare the student for all of the adult work they will encounter.

The prepared environment should include: health, vocation, intellect, and spiritual life. It is a dynamic living entity passed on from student to student. You have to have faith that the students will be able to learn in textbooks (15-18 years old) when that time comes because they have already lived the experience of learning the disciplines through practical work.

Social Organization

Jenny Höglund June 29, 2023

“Opportunity to penetrate into the great humanity and understanding of society.” This should be social education. The gratitude that comes from knowing work should come as natural as the human tongue. Adolescents require a certain type of living society with the hopes to achieve social independence. For this to happen, there needs to be a social organization guided by the sensitive periods. They have to do adult work and earn a living. There needs to be mixed age groups which foster interdependencies and discipline. It should underpin moral development. They should have interaction with various adults. Adolescents have a sensitive period for *personal dignity* and *justice*. So what is a social organization? What do you envision it to be?

Definition: The social organization is like the glue. It’s central to the adolescent community. It is not a school. Renilde Montessori corrected everyone to say “work and study” not “school,” and we are “adults.” It is an aid to life and the holistic personality. It can be thought of as a set of systems by which the members of a community functions independently and interdependently.

In Education and Peace, Montessori says that we must promote the freedom of the individual and the development of the personality.

Personality: Montessori had a psychological approach to personality and it has a lot to do with her methodology. Psychic energy and reflexive personality is a huge topic to explore. Montessori saw personality as one’s mental and physical potentialities. The combination and interaction of these determine your personality.

Four Mental Potentialities:

- ❖ Intellectual: Ability to comprehend, analyze, and synthesize
- ❖ Effective: Concerning with feelings or attitudes

- ❖ Volition: Your will, brain, sense organs, and muscles
- ❖ Morality: This is a learned pattern from grace and courtesy. When morality is internal, you have developed your own moral compass and code.

*The intellectual and moral capacities affect the volition.

The environment provides the opportunities for development of one's potentialities. It should be an atmosphere of freedom, and objects and materials to manipulate. If children are from a Montessori environment, then they have always been a part of a social organization.

The social organization is a continuum. "What is constant across the planes of development?" "What are the things that do not change?" The social organization is ever growing roots of belonging, becoming, independence, and responsibility. All of this begins with the love of the child and their parents.

- ❖ First Plane 0-6: Parallel individuals working in the community. They are kind and helpful. They take care of the others. Society by cohesion is bonded by love. This happens by adaptation during the first plane.

Normalization is a first plane phenomena. It is hopefully an outcome of the first plane. It is centered around focus and concentration. Also, will or volition that contributes to society leads to self-discipline.

- ❖ Second Plane 6-12: They are looking for individual cosmic tasks. They are introduced to cosmic education. The work of the intellect in groups is what bonds them. They can appreciate the intellect of others. How will they take care of their environment? The going outs in the community are important. Towards the end of the plane, they have the 6th Cosmic Fable, *The Great River*, which is about the human body, but also a metaphor for society.

❖ Third Plane 12-18: It is a lived society bonded by adult work. It is effective practical experiences of every aspect of life. The human personality must realize their capabilities. They have social practice of production and exchange. They have connections and interdependence with others. They handle money. They have individual and moral grounding which develops in community. It comes with maturity to own up to your actions. Within the context of morality, the idea of responsibility must be serious and we shouldn't use it loosely.

Montessori says that work and responsibility are denied to children. The only thing asked of children is to take the trash out, feed the animals, bring home good grades, and don't get into trouble or get pregnant in adolescence.

Work

Adolescents need to experience the hardships of failure. We do want to set them up for success, because we don't want them to experience extreme hardship. We also shouldn't remove obstacles all of the time. The environment should be safe, supportive, and loving. We should never speak about the person or poke at their center. We focus on action and events. Make sure to give them reflection time in journals. *Maria Montessori says*, "Work is not what we do for a living, but what we do for our living." Leisure is not the opposite of work, nor is play. The opposite of work is not investing in anything. Life's greatest joys are not what one does apart from work, but with the work. We want our children to find work that invests their body, mind, and spirit. That is something that we all need.

"The attitude you bring to all life experiences can never be taken from you." This quote came from a man that Jenny heard speak, who lost his whole family in the concentration camps.

Each person has to find a place in the social organization. How can you make yourself useful? How can you make a meaningful contribution? What kind of work do we offer them? To have consequences you have to have real work. Adolescents are transitioning to adulthood from childhood. We have to keep that in mind.

Because of the needs of the adolescent, self-discipline is always enacted. Social organization is very different from adult life because the environment is unprepared. It all has to be lived in the adolescent campus. Morality can only exist in a social context.

1. *Formation of Personality*
2. *Said Construction of the Adult*
3. *Social Individual*

Qualities/Characteristics of Social Organization

- ❖ Sense of Purpose: Purpose keeps us motivated. Recognizing and fulfilling our potentialities. Volition is when you have the will to do this.
- ❖ The most satisfying work is when we put our efforts towards things that we have in mind. They work for others and depend on others.
- ❖ Accountability is not imposed by adults.
- ❖ Loyalty: is connected to purpose.
- ❖ Freedom: to allow us to act on individual initiative. It must have limits and rules providing structure. Freedom to run community life.
- ❖ Morality: Relation with other people. It is a form of adaptation. Morality underpins everything.

Practical Considerations

What do we owe each other as a mixed age group? Needs and characteristics are the same, but they may manifest differently. There has to be space and opportunity for the adolescents to grow. The older students can take on true adult roles. They don't like working alone. When you have students that are 16-18, you can help them prepare for higher studies but they can still be part of the community.

Production and exchange is a very important practical part to make sure it is in place. Equity is very inherent. How do we work with differences? Inclusivity is important, as well as division of labor. There should be a connection to morality and justice. How we set things up could be very

different than they are used to. Observation will help guide us through. Listen and make suggestions.

Decision making: How will it look? Adults don't vote. You can have an opinion by saying things like, "a few years ago, a couple of students tried..." Rules are necessary to retain order. Stay with the rules and expectations. Don't ask anything of them that you don't do yourself. They really value when you are there 100 percent.

Adults should have the same standards in terms of expectations. (feet on the table, put supplies away...etc.) Adults must be in line and you have to protect this and Montessori's word. It is the adolescent's at risk here, not the adults. It is easy to slip into a compromised situation.

The ideal community size is also dependent on the size of the property. But, everyone should have work and be needed.

Outcomes of the social organization: morality, interdependency, division of labor, economic independence, earning and spending money, form relationships, association, freedom, responsibility. Association stimulates new energy. Adaptability, build up of love and compassion. This man has genuine qualities; love is different from attachment. Compassion means to *suffer with*. Empathy in Greek means *affection*.

Educational Syllabus: Introduction

Jenny Höglund, June 29, 2023

Education is an aid to life to contribute to the man and his personality. Man's development during each plane:

- ❖ First and Second Plane: Construction of Man
- ❖ Third Plane: Development of personality and the construction of the individual as a social member of society.

This leads them to the social organization of the adult. Education is indispensable. You achieve this from a Center for Study and Work. Build a life environment that concretely represents things that should be learned. The prepared environment does this. They need to live within the society but also study society.

Schedule

There can't be a schedule. They can't all do something at the same time. Having a fixed schedule eliminates spontaneous work. Because this creates students that just sit around and then no one does anything until the teacher comes. When we get our students used to a schedule, they will not manage the flow of their own work.

The Plan of Study and Work can be a guide and the Educational Syllabus provides the components necessary for adult life. It involves:

- ❖ *Self-Expression*: to find out who they are and who they are to become. It helps them connect to others. It helps them discover something they did not know. Provides different mediums, emotions, and new ways of thinking. It is related to art, music, and language. It requires imagination and free choice. The ultimate goal should be more understanding among men, helping them to develop solidarity and empathy. The spiritual aspect of education should not be neglected.

2. *Psychic Development. These are necessary for human development: **moral education, mathematics, language.***

Morality is in everything that they do. It should be a part of every educational situation. Psychic development helps them to listen to the inner voice so that you can listen to others.

Lez Pascal said that we are all born with **mathematical minds** and we need this to understand the world. Sometimes they need materials to fully understand. Understanding statistics and math helps solve problems, argue, explain everyday decisions, calculations, outcomes of situations, and courage to be honest.

Language creates an understanding between individuals. It helps with clarity of the mind. The mind should pull languages as early as possible. The first plane (0-6) is the sensitive period for language. One face should have one language for a child.

The Center for Work and Study

Montessori calls the work at the center the “Study and Work Plans.” Hershey in the United States calls it a “farm school,” but it is not a school. It is a “Center for Work and Study,” so Swedish students changed it. It should have many things to work on. It shouldn't look perfect.

Work

We don't know when work will become conscious for them. The minute they make a choice, it is a commitment. We want to help them become inspired, engaged, and find pleasure in the work.

Community Work

Care of the environment has daily, weekly, and monthly tasks. Keep a running list of things that need to be done and devote one day of the week to this work.

Educational Syllabus: *Education in Relation to Psychic Development- Moral Education*

John MacNamara, July 5, 2023

Moral development is the basis for all other forms of equilibrium. It is closely tied to the third plane of development. The inner development of the psyche is difficult to consider in its entirety. Psyche refers to the development of the mind and soul of the personality. It is important to approach adolescents with a sense of respect by considering their inner growth. Valorization is a process that enables a sense of maturity as well as a coordination of one's potentialities. Man has a weak body but a great spirit compared to animals. For the man, the spirit is the central part and the body is secondary. The animal is guided by the body, and there is little space for the spirit. If work satisfies the spirit, the individual feels satisfied and refreshed as opposed to tired.

Students possess an active psyche that needs development and cultivation. Children are undergoing an awesome task, and adults' role is to support them in this process. Therefore, children are the spiritual builders of humankind.

Moral development should be the highest purpose of education, but in the content-driven curriculum, this is neglected in the child's development.

Moral development comes into conflict with the idea of accumulating knowledge. Education needs to be an aid to life in the physical and emotional sense. The objective is not to fill the child with information; the educator needs to support the child to reach a great level of reasoning.

Comprehensive approaches talk to their students about character and morality, and it is assumed that these can be discussed without developing morality and strength of character. Learning the virtue of self-control or compassion is internalized through interacting with the environment. The environment has a significant impact on the development of children and adolescents. One cannot control the behavior of students; one can only influence them.

The role of an adult is to help students learn to manage their own behavior. The adult does not control the student's behavior. Moral development is obstructed by the "wrong work" given to the student. Students are often underestimated, and adults overestimate their contribution. The key is to make sure that the adults and the students are fulfilling their proper roles. Discipline is reached by indirect means, not by attacking a mistake. Consciousness is intensely developed during adolescence, and school does not respond to this need by neglecting altruism. Children need to develop consciousness by being independent thinkers; this is very different from imposing a point of view. They need to be offered possibilities and options to reflect, construct, and develop their sense of morality. Virtues cannot be taught, but they can be experienced in a free environment. With these conducive conditions, they can naturally manifest. The children absorb the values of kindness, loyalty, generosity, caring, respect, etc., which are perfected during the period of adolescence.

Encouraging self-reflection and experience is an approach that will lead to a morally mature individual. Montessori is composed of a moral dimension. One hopes that children will not only learn what is right and wrong but also love to engage in these positive actions; we hope that they will "fall in love with virtue".

A successful life depends on self-confidence and powers of adaptation; knowing how to help man in many ways fills the individual with dignity. The Montessori environment encourages reflection: "How am I good?" rather than "How good am I?". It is a qualitative reflection, not a quantitative reflection. Adolescents need to attain knowledge of how they are good and develop a feeling of confidence in what they aspire to within their reach. Once adolescents know the truth, they will grow to love and live it. Living this way is practiced and experienced within a small community. Small-scale experiences with their friends, a community of humility and respect, etc. are essential for these values to become real on a planetary scale. The environment that frees their mind and soul enables the greatest form of development.

Morality is a form of adaptation by the individual in relation to a community to achieve a common life in order to achieve a common aim. The focus is to cultivate a loving individual who knows the difference between right and wrong so these values can be passed on to their children. This type of

education enables children to redefine ideas on their own terms and gain an understanding of what happiness means to them. As an adult, the biggest challenge is being hypocritical and not truly exemplifying what one preaches. However, this aspiration is still.

Educational Syllabus: *Self-Expression*

Jenny Höglund, July 17, 2023

The Appendix B from *Childhood to Adolescence* refers to the components of the educational syllabus as the “Plans of Work and Study.” The plans aim at valorization of the individual. Valorization is not just feeling good about oneself after performing a song at coffee shop. We are not in the business of students acquiring a high paid job, but we are in the business of *aiding their development*. The environment is key to any plan of work. It is there for the sake of development. All adolescents come with energy that needs to be directed.

The objective of education is not to instruct, but to illuminate life and offer key concepts for awareness.

Work has become so specialized that some of our other talents have never been nourished or discovered. Education should give value to all aspects of the human personality. All of life’s needs should be at the center of education. We should offer adolescents *real adult work*. What does this mean exactly? Real work has a control of error built in. They will learn from the environment. They don’t need us to correct them. Academic work stems from this real work. *Montessori speaks* about observations of nature which enrich the mind. This triggers the study of nature and human life.

Introduce them to the heart of social life through experience and study.

It’s important to experience the power of the group. They come to appreciate order and organization. *When you have education based on the human personality, the curriculum cannot be at the center*. The national curriculum has to be there to give direction, but not requirements. It’s only used as a reference. The study and work is not based on this and it shouldn’t give any obligations. Students at Rydet are presented with the national curriculum, so that they know where

they can start in terms of national curriculum. We need to offer them even more than this. The students do manual work, practical work, and pursue their intellectual studies.

In this environment, students who are engaged in the manual work, translate that to their intellectual work.

You become very good at managing your own time. You become more efficient and disciplined. Some students also choose to work on Saturdays and Sundays to their own satisfaction. They don't consider it 'forced labor.' They enjoy their work.

There are many disciplines listed in the educational syllabus. The students are in charge of the subjects areas and they must receive grades. But, what is the role of the disciplines? If we don't know how and when to present the disciplines to each individual, it could fall flat. Everyone will not be interested in physics at 9:30 AM on Tuesday.

Montessori never wanted to use the word method. That insinuated that there was instruction. But, pedagogy was so much more and it is a three part noun.

1. How do we view society?
2. How do we view the individual? Do we view them as an empty body to be filled with knowledge? Do we believe there is an inner guide and all of us and natural skills to be nurtured?
3. How do we view knowledge? Is it what only comes out of the books? Is it handwork?

Montessori viewed her plan of education as a psycho-pedagogy. Montessori took the disciplines and uses them differently in each plane. She distributes the subject area knowledge between the planes of development, depending on the psychology of the child during those planes.

In elementary, presentations are two parts and first deal with the psychological presentations. Montessori put important materials in a golden color. The psychological component is such an important part. It determines how the disciplines should be distributed.

Adolescents have social and economic independencies and a developmental task. Each plane has its own independencies, but there's also a general independence of adult work. The ribbon exercise helped us psychologically to see how things are so interconnected. It's important for the adolescents to see the disciplines in an interconnected way. Adults try to control the experience, but adolescence embrace everything in totality. Adults can overanalyze and complicate things.

In this prepared environment, there are natural consequences that are felt if dinner is forgotten, the animals are not fed, and so on. At home, parents may fix these issues for them. The subject areas are useless if they are standing alone. In Elementary, they can start to identify the subject areas. In elementary, there is an enormous amount of nomenclature to discuss with proper vocabulary.

3 Period Lessons in Previous Planes

1. To name things and isolate.
2. The longest part. Get the idea that the child can associate.
3. Now can they name the items?

3 Period Lesson for Adolescents

1. Presentations of necessary information
2. Exploration and work
3. Adult brings them together to help them become aware of the work that they have done

They explore, discover, but there is no way to cover everything. Working in depth on one thing is more useful than a bunch of superficial studies, because they go really deep and honor their concentration and discipline. Sometimes specialists can be helpful in these situations. The best methods arise maximum engagement in the student. They need spontaneous work, rather than forced work.

Adolescents are interested in the history of things. Disciplines are there to perfect the adolescent. The last two years of the third plane are for perfecting the physical aspects of the adolescent. The

last two years they can pursue an interest if they choose. We want the students to enter into society with some dignity, personal justice, and a mission (spiritual).

The study and work has to be geared towards life today. What tools and knowledge do they need to identify the interdependencies today? How do we provide experiences to help them? See that things can be changed? It's a very holistic approach. We want them to have the best of knowledge and understanding so that they can bring this forward. Technology, science, what we've inherited, what we use, what we share, and where we are going.

It's important to not have a schedule. It leaves very little time for independent work, reflection, and spontaneity. Access to books, documents, letters, explorations of new things and old things. There should be plenty of opportunities to explore their feelings, geography, and world differences.

Self-Expression

There should be many opportunities for the adolescents to practice self-expression. This is for them to discover who they are and offer it to others. They can explore new media, new emotions, and new ways of thinking. You can invite more specialists for the self-expression units. The units can utilize art, language, imagination, and free choice. It should be a daily practice. *Montessori* says art, short stories, novels, poetry, and acting are all important. Students have had self-expression through all of the planes of development in the forms of music, art, and language.

Music

The goal of music is to activate humans. To be touched at our inner core. We sing a lot. Music therapy and religion help to accomplish work. Rail workers sing while working. Music has been a weapon in politics. Self-expression and music go hand-in-hand. Music seduces us at Christmas time. Music is a language, the most international one. The risk is that we stop listening to music. How have humans throughout history used music? We all experience music in different ways. When you listen to music from a certain time, it brings back emotions. *Socrates said* that music plays the largest importance in bringing up the child. He who hears the music will make him noble as well. Music is so important for adolescents: to play and to sing. Make music a big part of their

life. Music is a very important part of self-expression. You have to have opportunities available and ready to go when one is inclined.

Language

Language is a characteristic that distinguishes man. It's an expression of the human spirit. It makes us superior and powerful. We must know our language. It is a tool of invention. Linguistic abilities help us to receive the spirit of others. It is important for the adolescent to read and write poetry. We should share poetry with our students. We should practice writing and giving speeches. We should practice debate, discussions, and be part of conversation. Grace and courtesy is important, knowing when and how to say something. Freedom and speech comes with a limit. We use language to comfort, communicate, and journal one's thoughts. We use it to achieve independence. We use it for dancing and drama, acting out stories and events. This gives experience for tolerance, empathy, and respect. Drama can be monologues or group plays where everyone has a part. There should be no auditions. It is work that allows adolescents to discuss characters, and explore human behavior and thinking. They are trying to figure out who they are and how others perceive them. Language is an accomplishment, and everyone takes it to a different level. Sometimes self-expression is favored at the cost of grammar. *"Language is the fruit of our spirit."*

Art

Why do humans create images? There's a golden thread connecting human encounter with nature. How do we think and relate to the world? "Art will be dead if no one looks at it." It really comes to life when you look at it. You can look with others and have students present on certain paintings. The life and story of the artist. Look at a painting in a way we haven't before. You can also have art seminars. Galleries have experiences in time and space to help us enjoy art. You can consider the earth as a work of art. Supernature is a human made environment. Art has a rule to play because our story is preserved. Everything changes so rapidly. Art is important from that point of view. Drawing is important. While doing art, there are natural moments to reflect and create. They also need to learn different techniques.

Self-expression helps the adolescent to find their authentic self. To express yourself helps to develop your personality. It helps to develop the true self and to feel comfortable. Do not short change self-expression.

Educational Syllabus: Language

Jenny Höglund, July 20, 2023

In the educational syllabus language is mentioned in self expression and psychic development. She also says one should read and write in many languages. Maria said that *“though it is nothing, it has magical powers...we can make images in the mind...we can make people vibrate in their spirit.”*

We all have a tendency to communicate. We take the ability to express ourselves for granted. Reading and writing is all around us, but language is hard to grasp. It is always changing and growing. Words are always being added. Language is important in the Montessori environment. Language is always there. To read what someone has written, past or present, is truly marvelous. Language is important for becoming part of a group. The small child adapts to their time and place and it requires the reality of language. Spoken language divides us, but the written language unites us.

Mario said that *with the alphabet his thoughts could be heard from every continent*. Children do not go to school to learn a language, they take their language with them to school. With young children, never dumb them down with baby voices and language. Speak to them as an adult. Don't make the sentences simple. Support language acquisition. We must know where they are and set out to take them to the next level.

Montessori said, *“Spoken language is developed naturally and in every man. Without it, he would be miserable: a deaf and dumb creature.”*

To be able to write used to be a privilege and symbol of power. To write is a question of conscience. We can write in joy and in anger. How we express ourselves depends on our personalities. When you write with the moveable alphabet, it's important for them to see you think first. Now, when you write, it depends when and how. You write differently for different types of situations.

Style is the writer's voice. We have to help them find their voice before they can sing. Reading is wonderful because we can see the different voices of the authors. Adolescents need practice doing this. They need motives to write. When they practice, you'll find that they grow. Our aim is not to make professional writers out of the children, but help them realize the potential for creative writing. Once the word comes out of our mouth, it functions on its own. Elementary students do a lot of nomenclature. They use so much vocabulary.

Writing is the communication of one to another. It helps us express our thoughts and create understanding. In order to engage children in reading, it needs to be exciting and purposeful. Children should never feel less than because they don't have the vocabulary. Vocabulary isn't done through study. It comes through reading, conversation, and through context. It isn't a helpful technique to just learn a list of Spanish vocabulary. It needs to be in context. Nine out of 10 words that we use, we learned by what we read. We read for information, understanding, or pleasure. Each type of book should be approached in a different way.

4 Reasons to Read:

1. To be a better partner in conversation.
2. A neighbor will never say you read too loud.
3. Books have stopped bullets.
4. Dinosaurs did not read and look what happened to them.

Books describe other lives and choices, most of which we will never experience ourselves. When reading is combined with math, geography, and history, it can teach us about the world and ourselves. Language signals civilization. The ability to collaborate and cooperate. Language strengthens a community and is an expression of the human spirit. Throughout history, people have shared their experiences for the benefit of others. Adolescents need language so that they can discuss and reason with each other. They need to verbalize their thinking. To verbalize one's thoughts based on knowledge, gives independence and a feeling that one can think for themselves.

Language provides a clarity of vision and thought. It should feed the ability to ponder. There's a good book called *How to Have Intelligent and Creative Conversations with Your Kids*.

Language gives us the possibility to live more reflectively. It supports moral independence in people and situations. If we are aiming for solidarity and compassion, they need a language for this. We will witness the rising of a new man. Life today makes our adolescents more mentally passive. There is another book called *Politically Correct Bedtime Stories*, which is a fun read.

It's also nice to keep a book diary of what you are reading. You can record where you are and the date to look back on. *Adults in the community must model a joy of reading for the adolescents.*

Preparation for Adult Life

Leslie Ann Patrick, July 17, 2023

All of the disciplines are to serve the adolescent. As we approach the subjects, we have to think about how we can apply the sensitivities. There are a range of skills which enable them for future career paths. We should apply the chart of interdependence with the adolescent work. They will recognize the disciplines. They should have freedom to explore these subjects in the Work and Study. They should have ways to explore their individual interests. Experiential work as well as study. This should arouse maximum interest in order to hook the student into that discipline.

It's not a transmission of knowledge. It helps them explore, gather data, cultivate research, and skills for the third part of the syllabus. It's like working with soil versus listening about soil. Montessori lists things that the adolescent should have access to. Part three of the syllabus is divided into three parts.

1. Human Sciences
2. Human Progress
3. History of Humanity

1. The first part of the syllabus says that we should invite adolescence to observe. To go into the natural world. How does the water flow? What does the soil consist of? They should explore the natural world. They are confronted with the responsibility to maintain the natural world. There's future stewardship of the natural world. They must know and love it enough. They need to live it. They incarnate sustainability. They need to encounter natural cycles: water and interdependent relationships through meaningful work. We should help them see themselves as part of this work. They need to understand themselves in their brains. We need to talk about food, exercise, and mental well-being. They need to use their imaginations and manipulate inventions.

2. This leads the adolescent into the second phase of the syllabus: to honor the wonderful progress humans have made and look forward to the future. Moral education comes into play here. ***The Museum of Machinery*** is used to see the evolution of invention. Adolescents should use, manipulate, and repair old and contemporary machines. They encounter a change in perception using both integrated and contextualized knowledge. Creation and destruction are very closely linked. Through their activity and research, they become informed about how to act.

3. *Part three of the educational syllabus is history.* History is the backbone of Montessori and the underpinning of everything. Who were the first people on this land? Why did they choose between the creek and forest? They start to study the land where they are. They are part of the human story. This is not the time for adolescence to go out traveling. In order for them to benefit most, they need to really learn their roots. We look to human history for information about all cultures. There's an influence of religion, patriotism. These are the challenges in the contemporary world. We don't want to paint a gloomy future. We want to shine light on optimism. *"I know that with others we can make great change."*

Explorers and Inventors

We look at creativity and invention. What do I need to know? We don't dwell on the past or dark periods. We focus on where we want to go from here. Human beings want to get it right. We depend on our neighbors. We should help each other without taking over others. This is the power of the residential program. When adolescents leave, they really feel like, "I can make a change in the world!" They are passionately interested in politics, part of living and having real conversations together.

1. Tools
2. Windows of interest
3. Use the skills you enter into the disciplines

"Now, I am interested in history and I never was before." said a fourth plane person. The seeds sown need time to bloom. In the third year they can really research at a different level. They can do an in-depth study of one person and event. You won't get every discipline into every Plan of Work and Study each time, but overtime you can get many. The plane has a sensitivity for **dignity** and **justice**. How do we create opportunities to incorporate these sensitivities? **The developmental task of the plane is to know society.** Artificial intelligence is human progress.

"In the soul of adolescence lies the intimate vocation of man." Maria Montessori, *From Childhood to Adolescence*

We should always give a non-judgmental view. We should listen to music of mankind, and expose them with an open view. We should give them an international view of other languages, and incorporate this exploration. **As long as there is a schedule, freedom will be compromised.** They do need to have a framework and a timeline for their Work and Study, so that there is success in a good amount of time. 16 to 18-year-old's studies can go longer than six weeks. You can't tell them to stop now. They are interested, but they need time and space to explore. It needs to come from a real need, not just what the adults think would be good for them to study.

The school is completely based on the framework of Study and Work. You can't recycle different units, it never works.

Preparation of the Adult/Role of the Adult

Leslie Anne Patrick, July 17, 2023

We are not the teachers. We don't need any teachers. Pedagogy must follow the psychology of the third plane. Observing the tendencies and the sensitivities. These are the two most important things for the adolescent:

1. The adult with limited intervention
2. The prepared environment

How do we prepare an environment suitable for them? The environment belongs to the adolescents. There are three preparations needed for the adult:

1. Technical
2. Intellectual
3. Spiritual

Montessori says that a guide should be a servant, a scientist, and a saint. Are you in good health? Or are you always stressed, prone to depression, and feeling unwell? The adolescent will bring energy and you will have to meet them. How we look, dress, speak, and move is noticed by the adolescents. They look at our interests and they share our passions.

We must never underestimate the influence that we are projecting.

Expectations should be clear and held. If they are, we will have a safe, joyful, and at ease environment rooted in grace and courtesy. We should draw on the adolescent's sensitivities. How do we support their **personal dignity** and **sense of justice**? *We must understand their developmental task to understand society.*

We can't hide behind a curriculum, we have to pull everything together. We can't stay in our comfort zones of intellectual capacity or technical work. We have to refine our expertise to meet

their developmental task. To be an adult in the adolescent community, we have to be prepared to work everywhere and on everything. We also need to embrace all of the adults in the environment. It is much more than lesson preparation. It is also *spiritual preparation*. We have to eradicate pride and anger from which our hearts are crusted. We must look within. What are my negative traits? What are my values? What are my system of ethics? We carry with us the wounds from our childhood. We must recognize these things, acknowledge them, and learn to move on. You can't say that we trust that the adolescents are self-constructing, and then say well we can help him do this or do that. Everyone is unique. We must love, trust, and have faith in them. It's not our place to shape them. It's our place to serve the potentialities so that they may shape themselves. Is the goal of education to have an attitude that is attached to power and possessions, or do you take life with a great sense of joy? *"A life well lived is one rooted and virtues."*

Montessori names the seven deadly sins. Are we up to this work? Am I in a good place to support the holistic development of the human?

In the environment, there should be a range of adults who demonstrate different personalities, because that is what they will encounter in the real world. There should be a house parent, Handy, person, specialist, agriculture specialist, residential teachers, and visiting teachers, who can cover a variety of subjects. Keep the number of adults to as few as possible. Too many adults who are not prepared will be the downfall of your program.

Adults become part of the environment, not ordinary teachers. The adults model experiences for them. We are part of the social environment, illuminating different aspects of adult life. Listen to the adolescents. Mirror their emotions, enable them to face challenges and conflict, comfort them, and most importantly, protect them, stand up for them, and advocate for them. Adolescents have a power that comes off as shyness. They are very creative and it is our job to be aware of their power. We need to take a special approach: we need to have adults working side-by-side with them. On the land, in the kitchen, on production and exchange, with their academic studies, and through community work. We have to be available for them and have materials ready and available. We need to support them through the completion of tasks successfully. The environment

must be organized with materials. Once you show them how to do something, you should stay with them until you know they have it. We have to be friendly, but we are not there to be their friends. We should have mutual respect, *but adults are the adults*. One of our biggest responsibilities is to keep physical order in the environment. Even if they are not keeping order, we must. Grace and courtesy around meals is very important. Communication must be very clear. They are good at interpreting things in their favor. Make sure to ask, “Who will take responsibility for that?” To help them with accountability. When they do things wrong; respect, encourage, and support them; but we must also show them the right way. Support them on this road to independence. Some adolescents need you at every moment during Work and Study. Some can do a large part on their own. If you say you’ll be back, you must come back. Reliability is very important with the adolescents.

Work and Study feedback and self-evaluation is important.

1. What went well?
2. What would you like to see more of?

It doesn’t matter which role we are in, we have to step into all areas. We must know adolescent psychology. You have to be on the same page as all of the adults. All visiting teachers/specialists must be given an orientation and materials, and teach in the Montessori way.

“Human teachers can only help the unfolding of the human soul.”

It is a challenge. You must keep humility. We are all flawed, but, have faith. It is no ordinary task. Read and have seminars with your fellow adults. We should always be working on ourselves and looking within. We must trust that the adolescents are in the process of self-construction. We can’t obstruct this. Set the bar slightly higher for them. All of the adult roles are there for a purpose. We have to think “What do these roles bring, and how can we invite these aspects into the environment?”

Farm Management

Leonard, April 17, 2024

Nature sets the farm schedule for us. There are managerial roles that are in charge of different areas on the farm. Each manager comes with their own concerns. We have a lot of conversations at meal times where people bring their ideas. If people think it's a viable idea they may bring it to the community meeting.

Farm areas can be focused on in the Study and Work cycles. I work with 2 students in the regular day to day schedule for the morning work period. Some students really want to work side-by-side and some are very independent and sometimes take a younger student with them. It's not always me that is there on the farm, it can also be some managers that have more experience. During community work, you have to be a little more careful how you assign the groups so they can work a little more independently with a mixture of ages.

The farm manager is there as a consultant and expert, the students begin to know nature's schedule. When new animals are purchased on the farm, the students discuss with the farm manager what the animals needs are with food etc., and the students have to figure out how to organize their care. The students are paid to take care of the animals in the summer, since Leonard is on holiday. But, on the weekends and school holidays, the adolescent's take turns caring for the animals, or they find someone to care for the animals.

The students came to the farm when the farm was first purchased, so the initial group got to help fix up their new home. It's important that they do not arrive to a fully finished school. If they get to help fix things initially, it helps them to have ownership.

All of the tools need to have a spot, the same spot. The tool shed needs to be orderly. Students need to arrive ready to work at 9am with gloves and the appropriate tools.

How to decide who works on the farm each day: the community talks at breakfast to see who will be on the farm during the morning and afternoon. Usually 2 people on the farm for the morning work cycle, and 2 people on the farm in the afternoon. It depends on a few things: who is cooking lunch and dinner? The kitchen schedule for the whole week, so they at least know this and can base the farm schedule around this. Also, some students may have something timely that they need to take care of in the school house, like a presentation or something, so they can negotiate this with the group. A different group of students feed the animals first thing in the morning and the evening.

Students should have general wood working knowledge and introduction to all of the tools in the workshop. In Sweden, woodworking is compulsory, everyone learns to drill a hole, saw straight...etc., before they go to middle school.

Exchanging information about how the students are doing? The adults sit together and talk at lunch and are in constant communication.

Adult preparation: if you are passionate and interested in what you are doing, that will rub off on them.

Adult meetings: Every quarter parents and students come in for a check-in (speed dating style). At the end of each Study and Work Cycle, students have meetings with each student to go through their documentation and see the work that they have done.

The Pivotal Role of Production and Exchange

Leslie Anne Patrick, July 17, 2023

This is the most important part of what we do. It synthesizes the manual work. Production and exchange becomes the golden symbol. It is the work of the human hands. It's the ultimate possibility for the hands to be put to such great use. It provides the adolescent with social and economic independence. This means that it aids in the cultivation of the young adult personality and society. It helps them to realize their authentic selves.

Economic Independence

This is more than just earning money. It's meeting all of the fundamental needs. What does this look like in an adult society? The prepared environment should prepare them for this. Montessori writes that the adolescent should explore the human relationship with money. Intrinsic attitudes about money come from our family lives and they define our unconscious relationship with money.

We should put a ceiling on the attachment to worldly materials. Our financial status does not define us. We help them to do this by helping them see what the purpose of money is. How does it function in their community? It never presents as a judgment of themselves. It sustains their community as a group. It creates a formation for shared morality.

Parents become an obstacle because they give far too easily. It's better if they're in a residential community. Parents are halting the development by giving them too much, too easily. It's like a bird and a comfortable cage. There are many ways that parents can help them feel economic independence. If they do this, we will see them develop a strong sense of self. It is as simple as going to the farmers market.

They begin to realize their own capabilities. She talks about the gratuitous benevolence of others. We know that by giving them money it does not serve them. They need to provide and contribute to their families. They have a sensitivity for personal dignity and justice.

They become very interested in the distribution of wealth. They become really interested in the moral and social issues of today. We need to take time to have these discussions. They want to fix and change things. They can start to formulate what they can do as adults. They have a lot of questions as they go through this process.

They have a lot of questions about production exchange, marketing, economics, and how to do this ethically. They know that their economic independence does not stand alone. Kindness, virtue, fundraising, markets, selling to parents, it's not just about selling to parents. They need to deal with the public, the people they do not know. They have the responsibility of community. They have to consider how not to waste money, save electricity, preserve material, etc.. Mathematics as psychic development comes into play here. Things like bookkeeping, financial communications, credit card management, handling real money, talking about taxes, business legislation around selling goods, graphing data around selling trends.

Could older students visit another adolescent community somewhere? They become capable of mature decision-making. How can we do this? We need a shop and a hotel. Where did the production ideas come from? The history of products and successful and unsuccessful items. They will decide themselves about what they can produce. The production of food for the community is important. They need to provide food for themselves, then the surplus can be sold. This all comes and goes in seasons they can also sell compost. Montessori said, *"May young people continue having the possibility where they produce beautiful things."*

Making crafts for sale is difficult for them in the public but, you have to have quality control. Which crafts are successful to the public? There are big ethical questions in production. The workshop wood comes from the forest. Which wood do we take? Where does it come from? Who

has suffered to make this available to us? When thinking about cheap book products. Do we make a profit using these goods that require suffering to make? These are the ethical and sustainable questions. We must ask ourselves also related to the packaging of our goods. It cannot just be about buying the cheapest items and making the most money. We need to consider society as a whole. La Nazione Unica.

There are 4 different types of work:

1. Manual Work
2. Work and Study
3. Production and Exchange
4. Practical Work

During the six week work cycle, students would not be doing production and exchange but they would have ongoing production and exchange work that happens during community work time. A lot of hand work would be done outside of the work and study three hour period.

When we do things for adolescents, we cheat them of the experience and work. There is a division of labor. Everyone should participate in production in exchange. This is one of the most important social skills. Everyone is needed. There is a role for everyone. Trips are not in Montessori literature, and do not replace residential experience. Production and exchange also does not replace manual work.

Grace and Courtesy: Our Human Responsibility

Jenny Höglund, July 19, 2023

Presented originally at the NAMTA Conference

Grace and courtesy is always with us. It is throughout all the planes. It is important for harmonious living, and for production and exchange. It is collected when a group of individuals come together. Education is meant to aid life. It should be adapted to time and place. As adults, we have to make it possible for the development of the human potential. There must be a will for it.

Grace is the harmony between mind and body. Courtesy is the harmony between one's self and others.

Grace and courtesy is considerate behavior and actions. The smile has to be from the heart. The will can be blind if it is not illuminated by the intellect. It starts in the home. Rukku speaks about language and movement. Courtesy is also the love and service to others. We don't need money or possessions, all we need to do is recognize humanity. It's not only about materials. It is about people in their lives. This is done out of consideration of others and courtesy is a topic thought about frequently because of how we interact with others and how things have changed. Once mastered and understood, it will stay with you for life and become an asset and a compass. Grace and courtesy must be maintained and nourished throughout life. For example, we greet each adolescent every morning because they each need to be acknowledged.

The reading called, *The Perfect Hostess*, from 1937 is about grace and courtesy, and makes for a very interesting comparison and conversation. Grace and courtesy creates a sense of security and orientation. Our current environment is changing and it may not ask for grace and courtesy from us. *Be mindful of what we adapt to.* We need to have the courage to say no when everyone else says yes. We want them to experience this in a safe environment. How is one best to live? Is this

when you make your life meaningful to yourself and others? Adolescents working with production and exchange and hospitality make decisions about how they want to represent themselves.

It's not always clear what is good for adolescents. We can react to what happens to us in a free way. We must help adolescents to see that this is a choice. We have freedom of speech, but we cannot use this to inflict upon others. Aristotle wrote about the forming of good habits, but these need to be done at an early age. This is why we have grace and courtesy presentations in the Children's House.

It's a very interesting project for adolescents to work with the elderly community. They spend weeks interviewing one person and learning everything about their lives. At the end, they give them a report or a presentation that they put together all about that person. It's a beautiful way to help the adolescence reflect on the life they'd like to lead and what societal contributions they would like to make.

It is good when communities have a code of conduct for the group. This helps them see when they are off. It is also a road to social independence. It's important to acknowledge each adolescent. Start your day in good spirits and end your day in good spirits. The code of conduct in civility is important in the community. Grace and courtesy starts from within the community. We want the adolescents to observe life. We are influenced by the environment and by those who came before us. The adults in the environment should model grace and courtesy. We have to be kind to ourselves. Everyone can be grumpy sometimes. It's nice for them to see that it's normal and this can happen to adults too.

Manners are very important. We should always pass food in one direction, offer our neighbors first, eat with a knife and fork, finish our plates, and always start with a little food at first. Adolescents want to understand the reasoning behind actions. They also need to know what is expected of them.

There is a Chinese proverb that says, *“Do unto others as you would have them unto you.”*
Everything you do to others, you do to yourself.

At the beginning of the year, there is always a course in morality and ethics course at Montessori Rydet. Morality is the sum of actions and norms in our community. Why do we accept these actions as valid? Then, we compare these to other people’s cultures. With freedom comes discipline and responsibility. Opportunities for good work provides a moral compass. Work is moral training. Adolescents have practiced grace and courtesy for many years. The best compliment is to hear how nice they are to one another. We want them to grow in an environment where it does not matter who they are or what they do. Their actions should reflect their intentions. The environment needs to be safe so that they own up to their actions. This will dissolve the instinct to lie. *Choices may come with guilt and regret, but those are there to remind us that next time we can make a better choice.* We have to have safety in the environment that allows for honesty.

Consequences are the serious effects of freedom. For adolescents to get on the road to social independence with self-confidence, they need to have knowledge of the rules in that community. The Code of Civility and Conduct should be decided on as a group. It will serve as a compass for adolescents to understand what is acceptable in their community.

Peace in the world starts with grace and courtesy in our communities.

The Art of Observation

Jenny Höglund, July 20, 2023

There were some great words that we heard in the training center in Dublin. They said that teachers must be observers. The adult must school himself in seeing everything, but intervene only when the child really needs help, which is much less than the adult thinks. The adult has to have a dual role of a guide and observer. They must also have a sixth sense that tells them what is going on behind their backs. The adult must be able to detach from the group while observing. The guide is child centered, not self-centered. Their insight comes from love. The Montessori approach is scientific and systematic. The adult continues to study the child through all his work.

Hilla Patel (3-6 trainer in London) said, *“If we wish to succeed, we need sound knowledge of theory and practice. Deep love, principles, knowledge and materials are not sufficient if we do not observe the child.”*

Observation is the cornerstone of our work. It makes it become meaningful and alive.

Observation things to different disciplines. **Observare** in Latin means to keep watch. This is what the teacher has to do instead of teaching. It is the preparation of the eye. It's like looking in the microscope so that you can see what you are meant to see. It requires willpower and preparation.

Preparation: We must prepare ourselves as scientists. We need to have the desire to observe. The observer needs to have:

1. Patience
2. Humility
3. Humbleness
4. No preconceived ideas
5. Set aside past experiences

We have to observe, but our job is not to be a psychologist. We observe just to help our own understanding of a student. Montessori says that *“the aid we can give to the adolescent here is to fully help him live their life in the present.”* Don’t think of the future. Look objectively at the world around without any wish or expectation. “You’ve been trained to make the child pay attention to you.” We need to wait patiently and objectively to arrive at conclusions. It’s not enough to know the material; we should know the conditions of their souls. We need to prepare ourselves for observation not by means of content but by methods meaning intellectual, technical, and spiritual.

Montessori differed from other scientists because she observed children in their natural environments. She borrowed procedures from the French Zoologist, Fabre. We observe students in their concrete lives and as a community. The child who chooses freely, takes pleasure in what they do. *Fabre said* that if his insects were captured, he would not be able to see them in their ideal state. You should record what you see, not what you think you see. You cannot make an assumption that someone is sad. There is a lot of mental observation going on. All great observers have great patience. We should observe one another, not to be a critic, but to help refine each other’s practice. It is nice to observe colleagues for professional development.

With children, you do not say “can you please?” Because, they are not doing you a favor, and you know that they *can* do the activity. Sometimes adults think they are helping, but they are interrupting. Observation is to help us become more mindful of our actions. With adolescents, you observe while working alongside them. When the adults come together, they should share observations with each other. It’s enlightening for your colleagues who work in different environments. ***For the third plane, it’s important to write down your observations.***

Language sometimes needs to be addressed. How is language being used in the environment? In Sweden, students are rarely using swear words. Observation has to be exercised overtime to form a clear picture of the group. You shouldn’t observe when you’re in a bad mood. If joy is missing in the community, you may decide to observe that day. But, you are always observing throughout the day in your environment. Keep a little notebook to record things that the students say.

Sometimes students drive each other to behave in certain ways. Montessori says that we have to reach a point where we work side-by-side and observe at the same time.

Observation concerns three areas:

1. Work
2. Conduct (order and disorder)
3. Obedience

Do they work with interest? Are they engaged? Is one tired or refreshed? You have to offer the right kind of work for each student, and the right challenge and choice. We shouldn't impose work on them. We should observe in relation to Montessori theory. Why are we doing this work? John Wyatt said, *"If you think you know what a student needs to learn without knowing them, it is like brain surgery in the dark."*

What we observe:

- ☐ Needs of each student
- ☐ Following the interest
- ☐ Finding out what their interest is
- ☐ Attention span (how long do they stay with work?)
- ☐ Exercising choice
- ☐ How do they deal with mistakes and problem solving?
- ☐ Independence at work
- ☐ Motivation for work
- ☐ Attitude towards finished work
- ☐ Using new skills and knowledge
- ☐ Order
- ☐ Sense of responsibility
- ☐ Taking care of the environment
- ☐ Self-discipline and control

- ☐ Sense of worth
- ☐ Social relationships
- ☐ Following the guidelines of the group

Why We Observe

We observe to discover their needs in terms of work interests, and interests that help them in their development. We observe to see how they exercise choice and how they achieve concentration. Do they need to be protected from chatty students? We observe to see how they solve problems, and how they deal with mistakes. For example, there are three students interested in a subject, so you invite them to join a math presentation, but it's their choice.

Conduct

We observe order to see who needs assistance. "*A blue rag is here, did somebody use this?* Did they tidy up? Did they help the group? We observe for self-discipline and self-control. We observe social relationships, kindness, cooperation, and helpfulness. Did the students follow the guidelines?

The Rydet community has a work circle that adolescents can color in. There is a minimum amount of work presented on the circle that they can color in, but they can add as much as they want to. It's for them to keep track of their work. They have the power over their work.

Fourth Plane of Development

Theory

Fourth Plane of Development: 18 to 24-years-old

Jenny Hoglund, April 5, 2024

Arrival to the Fourth Plane:

Maria Montessori refers to this plane as the Plan of Maturity. It is the second plane of adulthood. She says that at the age of 18, the adult is very much formed and developed as an individual. This is work that has gone on across the previous three planes. By the time they reach the fourth plane, we should have someone who knows their potentialities, possibilities, and responsibilities. Montessori says that it is only practical work and experiences that lead the young to maturity. She goes on to say that this is how a man of will and judgment is formed. The will starts to form at the very beginning of the human. We want the will to be guided by knowledge.

Work is a necessity. When the adolescents appreciate work, it gives them a moral orientation that will stay with them for life. Through the different planes, the children have been offered a variety of work and the opportunities to work in collaboration. They have explored through the work of the hands and the mind. These experiences have hopefully led them to become independent doers and thinkers. Montessori describes the children as having passed through the different stages of problems and development of education. This has given the adolescents constant opportunities to find out who and where they are. This also provides the possibility of refinement in terms of culture and individual qualities. The earlier planes should have led to “perfection,” especially in terms of making the necessary choices. Having been set in different social contexts, the children and adolescents have had a moral preparation which has hopefully left them with a strong character.

Montessori says, he who arrives at university, has left behind childhood and adolescence. A great part of his social destiny. It's not just about yourself, but also those around you. Montessori suggests that when they enter the fourth plane, they should be aware of the fact that they are part of humanity. Their world is also the world of others. The hope is that with this understanding, the individual cannot limit his or her life to personal advantages, but come to see that the self

becomes secondary. The goal of man is to exercise influence on civilization with one's time, to contribute to humanity.

Fourth Plane of Development

Nature has taken care of physical changes and the adolescent has reached maximum height. Over time, the body does still go through changes. But, not during the fourth plane. This is a period of calmness, stability, and good health. As hinted before, once the three previous planes have been completed and fulfilled, the fourth plane will automatically be successful. The psychological characteristics are more obvious during this plane. This is a plane of consolidation - of everything that went on before. Spiritual strength and independence can be further developed. The fourth plane is a plane of arrival. Since birth, they have been working on arrival to this point. An ever-widening of one's freedom and the responsibility that comes with this.

Mr. Grazzini (Four Planes of Development) Thus the individual passes through one plane of development to another, physical, spiritual, economic, all is urged by the force of nature itself. Which are apparent and irrepressible. To become a fully formed adult being..."

It is the construction of the personality reached by one's own experience. Montessori's concept of personality is more than just having a pleasant personality. Her understanding is the sum total of one's mental and physical potentialities. The combination and interaction between these potentialities. Physical is the system of relationships within the body. It is also the vegetative system within the body: blood, breathing..etc. The mental potentialities are divided into four areas.

The intellectual: your ability to comprehend, analyze, and synthesize. The effective: this has to do with feelings and aptitudes. Lastly, volition: which has to do with decisions and to will something.

Then there are the moral aspects: the capacity to make moral judgments. This is learned by young children, what is and is not appropriate. This should end up in the inner conscience.

Now, we can think about the interaction between the physical and mental potentialities.

Montessori calls this *behavior*.

Montessori says that a child's intellectual and moral capacities will influence the child's will.

Which in turn will guide the physical potentiality that will either result in moral behavior, which she describes as character. Or it will be unreasonable immoral behavior, which she refers to as deviations. In the *Absorbent Mind*, Montessori writes about devotions and obstacles in the child's natural development.

There is also an importance of the environment. The environment is not the cause for development, because that is an inner drive. It provides opportunities for developments of one's potentialities. There has to be two essential characteristics. An atmosphere of freedom and objects to manipulate. These characteristics will be different for each plane of development.

Intellect in the fourth plane:

The intellect comes back during the fourth plane. This is when human energies are being prepared. Responsibility and moral conscience have to rise to a higher level. This is so that the young adult can enter his or her mission in social life. In order for this to happen, there has to be additional moral and social preparation. That is what the fourth plane is all about. Moral and Social preparation.

It is at the age of 24 that one is ready to go out and do something in life. Sometimes we think that adolescents should do all of these charity activities and elementary children. But, from a Montessori point of view, they are not quite ready yet. First, they must experience all of these social and moral dilemmas so that they can use them as a framework and foundation for this further preparation that can take place outside in the real world. For an early adolescent, this experience would be pretty abstract. An older adolescent may be able to experience this in a different way.

The fourth plane is the time when someone will become an expert in a certain area. Because, they hopefully will be able to choose what they would like to do. They know who they are. They can choose based on self-knowledge. They are aware of their potentialities and responsibilities. Knowing one's potentials and strengths. It's also about knowing one's weaknesses and how to compensate for them. All of them are not strong in everything. They have to learn strategies to deal with their challenges. Students do actually have a very good understanding of what they can do and what will take more work for them. Not all students will apply themselves in this way though. The third plane helps direct them in these experiences.

The Fourth Plane is referred to as the plane of happiness. They are self-aware, confident, and working on some self-development/improvement. They are focusing on themselves, but they are aware of their part in society. Montessori takes this a bit further and says that if one is aware of one's potential and understands that, then the young adults should become aware of the potentials of human life. This is essential if we are to expect them to have a mutual understanding that everyone else has the potentialities that we have within them. This hopefully leads to an understanding that we are all part of humanity and working to satisfy our needs. Montessori describes this as being one nation, *Nazionale Unica*. They become aware of what they need from others and also what they can give others. They come to the fourth plane of experiences of how society works and also that being part of one comes with responsibilities. Now, they accept the responsibilities that come with being members of society, in the fourth plane. Also the idea that this is how our society works, but also as a nation and world.

They should also recognize the vision of interdependence of human life. This comes with the experience of a strong sense of community where there hasn't been much self-centeredness. If there has been a strong moral preparation earlier

They come with an understanding of humanity in the personal choices that they make. Love of Power, possession and easy life- if these are the temptations, one has to overcome those. One who no longer cares about these things, or domination over others, one may refer to these as

supreme spiritual beings. Responsibility is the very essence of human life. Montessori imagined everyone to have a cosmic task, but above all, there is a social responsibility attached to our lives. This responsibility would lead to a humanity that is able and willing to make a change. Montessori was nominated for a *Noble Peace Prize* because of her thoughts on this. She imagined the rising of a new man that would shape the direction of human society.

As mature individuals, fourth plane people have a higher level of moral conscience and accept the responsibilities attached to their lives. This comes with being a member of society. It's not just a question of being responsible, but also to deal with whatever consequences there might be related to one's actions. Values are behind all decisions. We are aiming for children, adolescents, an education where they are free to have values. This is different from an education where the requirements are to reproduce a lot of knowledge. But, this is a system where our students should be able to value, create, and transform in a direction that will ultimately result in progress which means a survival of all species. Both creativity and sound evaluations are based on integrated knowledge that goes beyond the limits of subjects. All academic disciplines are part of life. It is not compartmentalized into subject areas.

Maturity is to be free and follow one's own path in life as an independent and balanced human being. They also understand what it means to be economically independent. This will allow them to follow their own path. They are free to work- and all work is noble. The environment that Montessori speaks about is the university. She refers to this as a school for adults. Students continue to follow lessons, listen to professors, and pass examinations of which their careers depend. But, there are some differences. There is no homework and usually longer holidays. She says that many students are still dependent on their parents, financially.

University life has changed because of the lack of understanding of today's needs. Universities used to be the center of culture for knowledge. This made students more aware of their responsibilities. But now, it seems that in the 1930's, the mentality has become to do as little work as possible just in order to get the diploma. She also proposes that one should work during their studies to support themselves.

We have to consider that education is to aid life, all the values of human life. That should be the basis of education. It has to be a holistic approach. All aspects of the human being- we can't just focus on the intellectual aspect. There should be a coordination of education from birth to University. She talks about how they should be lifelong learners. It should not just be for immediate aid to get the diploma. It should be looked at through a lens of human progress- contribute to the betterment of the world. Whether it is the studies or work, it should help one find independence and one's social and moral equilibrium. The real examinations should be to work, prove their worth, and be recognized as valued members of society- this will help them to a higher level. Love of humanity and the environment will happen. The planes of development will support each other and enlarge the soul more and more. Maturity is the outcome when the individual is taken across the planes. Education has supported natural development. We cannot develop the needs of humanity with merely saying we must understand each other.

Maria says, man must develop in a way that he is capable of mutual understanding. For that, education must take man from his origin, with patience, and confidence across all four planes. School, culture, religion, and the world itself. The requirement is a labor of education.

At the end of the fourth plane, Montessori envisions a fully adaptable person. Capable of adapting to new situations, works for the good of himself and all of humanity. The task of education is to assist the child or adolescent in such a way that they must not become a copy, but to develop into the unique individual that you were born as. View the adolescent in such a way that we can see the opportunities that are there but might not manifest themselves in a way that one could expect. Ultimately, this is a time to further refine oneself as a human being in terms of social and moral understanding. So that they can understand the responsibilities that come with being a citizen of the world. Montessori also says that you can become trapped in a plane. She talks about this in the Four Planes of Development.

Third Plane

Methodology

The Seminar

Lecture on October 31, 2022 by Jenny Höglund

The idea of a Socratic Seminar is not from Maria Montessori, but practitioners found it to be very useful for adolescents. The goal of the Socratic Seminar is to search for the true meaning of the text by asking questions of the text. Seminar means to, “find seeds of thought.” It comes from the word “seminole” meaning seed plot.

Guidelines of the Seminar

- ❖ The seminar is an intellectual exercise
- ❖ Participants must always use the text to support their contributions
- ❖ Participants should come prepared with questions
- ❖ Dig deep into what the text is saying
- ❖ Broaden perspectives through other people's insights
- ❖ The seminar should have a structure and natural flow
- ❖ Everyone should contribute
- ❖ Sit in a circle
- ❖ Students should run the seminar
- ❖ Grace and Courtesy should be exhibited
- ❖ Remove all clutches: participants should only bring the text
- ❖ No tables to hide behind, beverages to drink, paper to write on...etc.
- ❖ The reason for no distractions is to demonstrate serious business. Let's really focus on understanding this text
- ❖ Participants should respond to the previous statements.
- ❖ Listening is just as important as speaking
- ❖ Participants should be mindful and intuitive towards one another and read body language, avoid interrupting, calling each other by name, and using eye contact.
- ❖ To participate, you must be prepared

- ❖ The people who are not prepared, should sit outside of the circle and have a job (taking notes, or drawing the communication circle)
- ❖ Order and precision are necessary.
- ❖ Make your comments very clear and concise.
- ❖ Explore others points of view. Disagree with the idea and not the person.
- ❖ One person should not monopolize the conversation. If it happens, the adult can step in.
- ❖ There are three types of questions that we like to discuss:
 - Evaluative: These are the questions that seek people's opinions. "What do you think..."
 - Interpretive: These are the questions of inference. "Why did Maria Montessori explain early childhood like this..."
 - Factual: straightforward answers that can be found directly from the text.

Types of Seminars:

- ❖ Short stories
- ❖ Chapters from Novels
- ❖ Non-fiction sciences
- ❖ Essays
- ❖ Poetry
- ❖ Math seminars
- ❖ Art seminars
- ❖ Intriguing advertisements
- ❖ **Music: listen to new music and ponder blindly**
- ❖ Philosophy: check out the philosophy book called, "**Sophie's World**"

The goal of the seminar is to think. There is no correct answer. You don't want everyone to think alike, so it is nice to hear others' points of view. You want to nourish each person to arrive at an answer in their own way. It helps develop problem solving skills. The seminar does not always have to be premeditated.

Example: There was once a student who did not speak during the seminar. At the end when they wrote their reflections, she said that she was very engaged the whole time. So, be careful to lay out clear guidelines in the beginning about expectations. After the seminar, especially if they felt very engaged and enthusiastic about the topic, have them write a personal reflection. This will help them solidify their ideas.

Ideas in Implementing Seminar

- ❖ If the students have been very engaged in the seminar, have them write reflections at the end. This will help them solidify their thoughts and opinions.
- ❖ Try the fishbowl method

Introduction to Journaling

Lecture by Leslie Ann Patrick on June 27, 2023

Elementary students use a journal to record what their work is each day. Adolescents have three types of journals.

1. Individual work journal: this is for them to plan out their daily work. They can set goals in this journal, write out their daily priorities...etc.
2. Community farm journal: not everything has to go into this journal, but important developments on the farm should go in here.
3. Personal Journal: the personal journal is very important. It is something that the guide reads and responds to. It will take students a bit to get comfortable with the journal. In order to help the students become comfortable with you reading their journal, you can start by giving semi-impersonal prompts...then, little by little you can start to give them open-ended prompts to write about anything. As the trust builds, they should open up more. This helps you to get to know them better and to be able to support them in the best way possible.

Community Work

Community work is not a part of the daily care of the environment. Community work is usually something that is part of the indoor or outdoor environment that needs to be repaired or completed for the betterment of the community and environment. Community work consists of various tasks that need regular, but not daily attention. The work is usually made up of larger projects that benefit community life in some way. The three-hour morning work cycle every Friday is dedicated to community work.

Everyone meets at the school house in the morning to determine what needs to be done on that specific Friday. Everyone arrives with work clothes on. For the first day, Leslie wrote a list of tasks on the board of things that she noticed needed tending to, and how many people were needed for each job. After the tasks were written out, Leslie went through the list and asked for volunteers for each item. There were things like clearing brush, trimming trees, mucking out the pig sty, and cleaning the roof. There was no guarantee that everyone would get the job that they wanted. There were at least 2 people needed for each job. If it was a larger project, sometimes 3 people were needed.

The adults let us know which groups they would be working with. The respective adults planned to meet their groups in certain places so that they could be oriented to using the right tools and the specific procedure for each job. We all headed to our workplaces and with the appropriate boots and gloves. The respective adults showed us where the tools were kept, and what our project goals were.

The day felt organized because everyone knew what they were going to work on and with whom. It was really nice that the entire community was busy at work at the same time. You would pass each other and see people in a nice flow of work, focused on what they were doing. There was a real sense of community, that we were all in this together. It felt good. There were no coffee or snack breaks during this 3 hour period. It was important for everyone to keep an eye on the clock

so that everyone could clean up their work areas and get cleaned up before lunch. This is a matter of respect towards those preparing lunch for everyone.

Community Meeting

The community meeting is held every Friday afternoon and is led by and for the adolescents. The meeting is led by the chairperson and secretary. Each week the chairperson and secretary roles change so that everyone gets the opportunity to hold these roles. The secretary becomes the chairperson, and so forth. The chairperson and the secretary sit in front at a desk facing the other students who are sitting in chairs in a half circle. The meeting is led by the chairperson while the secretary takes notes. The chairperson opens the meeting officially and welcomes everyone with a formal greeting. Then, they take attendance by reading through the list of students. Each student replies with “present.” Then, the chairperson reads the “*Quote of the Day.*”

There is a quick review of grace and courtesy, if needed. The students must always raise their hands before speaking, even when briefly replying to a question or comment of someone else. They are consistently reminded by the chairperson to raise their hand when they forget. This provides structure and encourages discipline and respect, so that no one may be interrupted while speaking.

The first thing on the agenda is the managerial reports. Each manager who holds a managerial position reports to the community on the developments and happenings in their area over the last week. The different areas of responsibility are animal, garden, production and exchange, hospitality, communication, and housekeeping. There may be questions, suggestions, or issues related to their areas of work which require brief discussion.

Afterwards, the chairperson moves onto the economy report. It is here that the financial situation of the community is reported and discussed. First, how much was spent over the past week and then how much is left over. There may also be a need to gather suggestions from the community for making more money. After this, the community issues are discussed. These do not have to be problems. They could also be questions or general matters of the community that require discussion or clarification and sometimes even a formal vote. If there are issues raised, it is important that the chairperson identifies who will help resolve the issue.

Following the community issues, the schedule for the next week is explained. Only changes or differences in the normal schedule are brought up. It could be announcing a visiting teacher, reminding of a community or small group trip somewhere, or a time change in seminar. Finally, the meeting ends with a round of acknowledgements. The adolescents should not thank each other for doing their daily duties. This is for acknowledging someone for going out of their way to help or provide a service to the community. At the end, the chairperson asks if there are any further matters to discuss and closes the meeting officially.

Care of the Environment

The care of the environment is everything to do with the cleaning and upkeep of the community living areas. These include things like cleaning bathrooms, watering plants, folding/ironing laundry, vacuuming common areas, and removing trash. The tasks are assigned either to an individual or to a group of 2-3 adolescents. Each task consists of additional subtasks and all the tasks with a description of its subtasks can be found in a binder in the entranceway to the house.

Each person or group has a specific task for an entire week. This supports the human tendencies to orient, to repeat, and to perfect. There is a specific time of day for the care of the environment, when everyone does their tasks simultaneously. This gives everyone a nice feeling of community and productivity.

Similar to in the first and second plane, there might be a material, such as a vacuum, that is only found once in the environment. This requires patience and understanding if this material is in use by someone else. This can be seen as an exercise in grace and courtesy.

When a task is assigned to a group of 2-3 adolescents, it's important that the group members communicate with each other about things such as when to meet to do the task, if someone will be late, or if the task needs to be taken over because one of the members is preparing food in the kitchen. The group has freedom to organize themselves as needed.

The tasks are not completely equal. Some take longer than others. Some require more movement. Some vary in the amount of work depending on the day. This gives perspective on the reality of equality and the distribution of work in society. However, there is a rotation which allows for change and balance. Also, if one is done very quickly, perhaps because there is little to no laundry on a certain day, one may choose to offer to help someone else finish their task. This leads to the development of empathy in the community.

Maths Seminar

John MacNamara, July 4, 2023

It's important that students share in the seminar. The whole class benefits from this. They should discuss ideas as frequently as possible. It builds opportunities to revisit concepts. There's a difference between agreement and validation. Adolescents don't need agreement, they just need to feel heard. I ask the shortest question I can, and then let the students build the question. Students should use their own approaches to math problems. By seeing how their peers each solved it, understanding why, how and when a problem went wrong is a crucial process. Allow them the space to solve problems in their own ways. Students have several days to sit, discuss, and reflect on mathematics.

When students come to the seminar, they have to write something for each problem, anything. The guide should ask as few questions as possible and find ways for all students to get involved. Problems are interpreted in so many different ways. You can think outside of the box for these. The adolescents will come to really enjoy volunteering for the math seminar.

Practical Process

Set up 5 chairs facing the whiteboard. Five adolescents volunteer to come to the center. They work through each problem and one person volunteers to come up to the whiteboard to solve the problem. If the entire group does not understand how they arrived at the answer, another person can volunteer to go up to the board and show how they arrived at the answer. Students will start to notice overtime, "Hey! I started the problem correctly." and overtime, it would slowly build their confidence in their thinking. Don't leave the problems unfinished. Come back to the problem at a later time.

Integration of Science into the Plans of Study and Work

John MacNamara, July 3, 2023

There is a thin line between encouraging and demanding. We have to be very careful. If an environment is properly ordered, students find great freedom and are willing to take risks. In Montessori, we have opportunities to work in a variety of ways, we have timely feedback, and daily encouragement.

Data Collection and Analysis

For math practice, we always use real data that the adolescents collect themselves. Data collection and analysis is the foundation. Real data is valued by the community. It is messy so it forces the students to use decimals and fractions. The data needs to be as genuine as possible. Things that they are really interested in knowing. They should observe and quantify.

Thinking is only for when you don't know the answer. It is not the knowledge, but the act of getting there that provides the greatest enjoyment.

My class is a buffet. They choose what is best for them. It is not one size fits all. How would this ever make sense in a community of individuals? Montessori is a student centered pedagogy. They can work on gathering data, recording, graphing and displaying, analyzing, correlation, cause and effect; there are not very rigid procedures. They can choose where they want to go with their projects. *They are always collecting data.*

There are several types of projects that they can do:

- ❖ Field Work
- ❖ Controlled
- ❖ Design Project
- ❖ Secondary Research

They explore projects like:

- ❖ Watering plants with rainwater vs. tap water
- ❖ pH of rainwater
- ❖ Field study about native plants
- ❖ Interviewing neighbors

You stand back and provide the structure and environment and they get so into it.

Real problems arise in the community and the students come together to brainstorm and solve them. They will do things like put together research to present to the board. The adults have to do the manual work with the students. When the students don't have a choice, it is all about you and what you want of them. They will not be truly engaged. You also don't know when something will click for a student. You have to be patient and take the 'long view' approach.

Creating Projects

When starting a project, students must write up a project plan. They should incorporate topic questions, sources, and when and how to present their findings so that there is an endpoint and follow-through. They do this by filling out a *Project Diagram*, which is a structured planning tool provided by the adults. They ask questions, make predictions, make decisions based on their research and investigation. As an adult, your role is to capture their attention and stimulate thinking. The goal is for students to be actively involved, experience genuine content, and create connections through real-life applications.

My role is to be a careful observer and to ask questions at the *right time*. Instead of dispersing knowledge to everyone, I set up the environment. I have to be a great listener to hear how they think, impose questions, challenges, puzzles, and riddles. I am not the citer of right and wrong. I am not the dispenser of knowledge. *Anything an adolescent can do, an adult shouldn't*. I believe that a published curriculum limits educators and students alike. When you rely on the curriculum, you lose your creativity. *If students like you, they will do what you want them to do. But, if you ask them, you are cheating them. "Education is what remains when we have forgotten all that we have been taught."* -Mark Twain

Montessori Approach taken to Maths as Exploration and Discovery

John MacNamara, July 10, 2023

Everyone must be involved in math otherwise you're sending the wrong message to the adolescence. Mental conditioning is just as important as physical conditioning. Memorizing facts does not mean they understand. Problem solving to solve real world problems is unlike anything else. *"It is well to cultivate a friendly attitude towards error."* To get an A on a test, you have to do everything you can to not make a mistake. We can't build an environment where we are scared to make mistakes. They are unavoidable if we want to learn, rather than be frozen by unsureness. The environment should be safe to make mistakes in. Trying to be a perfect teacher makes you an inefficient teacher. We shouldn't be afraid to make mistakes in front of the students. Generate answers on your own. Studies have shown that brain activity is different when you make mistakes and learn from them.

We want students to have desirable difficulties. Complex tasks are made into simpler tasks. Students control their own learning through control of error. The environment should have:

1. No fear of failure
2. Speed: there should be no timed tests in the environment.

The core of mathematics is reasoning. What is the need? Let's stop seeing it as just calculations. The idea of timing activities is not helpful. You can only do your best when you're on your own time. *"You can't afford to make a mistake, you can't afford to think out of the box."*

Shortcuts are harmful. They need to learn from their own reasoning in the primary classroom. They're not given rules of words or math formulas. They are discovering it on their own.

"Here is an essential principle of education: to teach details is to bring confusion; to establish the relationship between things is to bring knowledge." Maria Montessori

Mental math is so important. Make sure to do fun problems that use thinking outside of the box. It's not a math class just working out problems. It's a class where you're thinking about math and exploring. We are generalists. Take your math books and change them around to make the problems not into calculations. *Example: use six ones to make 27. You create a drawing with six lines to create a "27."*

The students arrived at the conclusions. It's the act of getting to knowledge that grants the greatest enjoyment.

1. Do not steal student's thunder. Don't jump in and show off.
2. Don't summarize students work at the end in a more polished way

If you summarize at the end, you are stealing their satisfaction. Adolescents also need materials. Happiest moments are when I get out of the way so that students can speak. They are capable of generating their own ideas. School is not a place for kids to watch and people to work. Help children handle failure.

A note from Jenny Höglund on generalists: We should strive for all of the adults to be present in all areas. Everyone does math seminars together. Be careful about saying things like, "I'm not the math person." Let the child discover on their own. *It's not your job to give the presentations or lead them straight to the "gold."*

Technology

John MacNamara, July 11, 2023

The Khan Academy came out with an article saying that chat bots will replace teachers. Technology doesn't matter in education. The fundamental role of teachers is not to deliver information, it is to guide the social process of learning. It is to inspire, challenge, and excite. Based on the social interaction between the community. What is the true role of the adult in the environment? The focus on education today has been to add more and more technology. They want you to use Desmos tech program. How can the future generation function if they learn math like this?

There are timed tests where they put structures in place to make sure that there is no way for a student to cheat. How can technology aid in a student's total development? Cursive writing is no longer being taught in many places in the United States. In Montessori, before students learn to read we teach them sandpaper letters.

1. Social emotional learning is the value of belonging
2. Strong relationship and strong community creates more engaged students

In Montessori, we can accept technology after these are nurtured:

1. 3 Period Lesson
2. Free Dialogue
3. Creative Writing
4. Materialized Abstractions
5. Collaborative Project
6. Data Research

We can't let technology take the place of the exciting human exchange. It's so important to also teach them global measuring systems, using pH strips before the sensors...etc. Technology

reduces the amount of time and human effort. It makes life easier, but they are shortcuts to avoid work. It's like driving with a GPS instead of a map. *Montessori* says to respect all reasonable forms of activity and try to understand it.

You have to be firm in your Montessori mission. What do we want from our students? When researching, students must also use books with internet research. Encyclopedias drum up curiosity. You never know what you'll read or stumble upon. Technology destroys the ability to critically think and problem solve in traditional school systems. There's no sensitive period for computers. There should be no tech in bedrooms, just one computer in the living space, and no cell phones. The introduction of computers doesn't start until 12 years old. My biggest job as a Montessori guide is to avoid being an obstacle. *Montessori* said that children learn best by acting on the environment around them.

Working with Students

John MacNamara, July 12, 2023

In Montessori, you are in a help and be helped classroom. Caring relationships are the foundation. People will never forget the way you made them feel. A student once told me that they would always remember the beautiful and thoughtful journals that we wrote. It's the power of words. They said that journaling as an adolescent was the reason why they continue to write now.

Adolescents need kind feedback and acknowledgment. When they do a presentation, they need feedback. Adolescence need:

1. Affirmation: I am accepted. I am safe here. People here care about me. They listen to me. It matters to them what I do well.
2. Contribution: says I make a difference in this place. I make unique and powerful suggestions. I am connected to others through mutual goals.
3. Purpose: What we do reflects me. The work absorbs me. What I learn here is useful to me now.
4. Power: I know what quality looks like and how to create it.
5. Challenge: The work stretches me. I work hard in this community. When I work hard, I succeed. But, not always

There are opportunities for rigger, thoughtful and authentic work, and self expression. The community should have self-discipline, dignity, free choice, and joyful interest.

There are studies about grit and how it is the best predictor of success. That grit is greater than intelligence. But, they miss passion. Passion is very important for adolescents. How do you tell students what to look for without telling them what to see? Busy students does not mean they're engaged. Students will do busy work if we ask them to, but they are not engaged.

What can we do to not kill the wonder, anticipation, and amazement in our students? It's not knowledge, but it's the act of learning. A montessori environment makes the world tangible and accessible. Self-expression in education is so important and what they will actually remember. They love to make movies and self-expression. In the Secret of Childhood, *Montessori says* that work flows naturally from interest and enables a person to express their own personality. The greatest aid to this is through freedom of work in their own way. Also, sound concentration. The character is changed in an authentic way. It's like you've taken off a mask. There's a great

importance of movement. There's a need to need, but also a need to be needed. There's a need for stillness and activity. I need to be alone and also belong. I need to love and be loved. I need to tease and be teased. I need to be responsible and irresponsible. With technology (cellphones), the need for stillness is being lost.

Trust, empathy, and affection is important in the community. Empathy is missing in the world today. My students experience these things. They need the realities of love and virtue, not lessons on these characteristics. They need to know that nothing they do will change that they are loved.

In the environment there should be:

1. Unconditional love
2. Space for growth
3. Mentorship
4. Freedom to learn from their mistakes

There's a healthy paradox: they are perfect, but still have a long way to go. *Montessori* says that patience is very important for teachers and parents. We trust ourselves, trust our students, but most of all we need to trust the Montessori process. They need an environment to experience community, affirmations, and love. A safe and enlightened place where they can test, discover, experience, share, and celebrate. Notice that there is nothing academic in the above needs. I see students graduate from my community that have principal, a sense of self, and awareness of personal worth. They love learning, to be curious, and to ask questions. We don't want perfect adolescents. We are raising prepared adults.

1. Structure: students make few decisions, but are not given any outcome goals. They're given problems and materials.
2. Guided - students are provided with materials, no expected outcomes, and they are not quite independent.
3. Open: students formulate their own problems and completely and independently of the guide.

I treated everyone alike differently. Are there any situations in life where one size fits all? How do I deal with the urge to compare? When something isn't going right in the class, I ask myself what can I do? In these moments, you must read Montessori. There's nothing more important. The growth mindset says that a person's true potential is unknown. *Montessori* wrote so much of what we now know in modern science. She said that nobody can grow for the child. She also said that forced growth weakens the plant. The tadpole will grow into a frog when the time is right. Mac doesn't use rubrics in his classroom. They are limiting and tell students what to do. It's harmful to

have one rubric to measure everyone. *We have to love each and every child that we work with. But, we don't have to like them.*

Documentation of Study and Work

- ❖ Mind Map
- ❖ Personal Goals
- ❖ Notes from Introduction, Presentations, Study Visits, Experts
- ❖ Math Seminars
- ❖ Self-Expression
- ❖ Movement, Physical Activities
- ❖ Other Seminars
- ❖ Individual Research
- ❖ Production and Exchange
- ❖ Skills Presented
- ❖ Coffee House
- ❖ Final Presentation
- ❖ Self-Evaluation

Vision and Culture

Jenny Hoglund, April 12, 2024

All schools should have a vision statement. Vision is where you want to be and culture is the way we do things and what will get us there.

Culture

Control: who is in charge? Who does the community go to when they need an answer? Who contacts administration if it needs to go to that level? (level development directors) Adolescents should be free to anyone and everyone. Who has a clear overview of everything going on in the community? (director of pedagogy)

Understanding: Does everyone understand why we do what we do? Whose responsibility is it to help those people understand who do not understand? (parents, colleagues, staff, specialists..etc.)

Leaders: How are leaders developed and deployed? Are they sent to training?

Trust: There has to be an “account” for trust. You can deposit into it and withdrawal from it.

Trust in students, Montessori, yourself.

Unafraid: fear cannot run decisions. Fearful that they adolescents don't like us enough, fearful to be firm with them. Fearful of parents. We need to be aware of where they are. Afraid of making mistakes so you never make changes.

Responsive: are you responsive to things that are critical to your success. To your vision and to Montessori? You have the knowledge of Montessori, but you are not implementing the ideas.

How do you respond to the framework that you agreed upon?

Execution: are you living your vision? Are you doing what you set out to do?

Evaluation: You have to evaluate and process what is happening. We need to observe and see growth in the community. Administration needs to see growth as well. This is what gives us energy to keep on. Are we seeing more independence, spontaneity, and work? Growth as a community?

Every now and again you need to stop and ask ourselves: where are we as an adolescent community? What has happened so far as a school year. Think in terms of social, practical and physical environment, and all the aspects of that. In terms of production and exchange. In terms of the education syllabus too- are we offering these opportunities for work? What about psychic formation? Is this being indirectly addressed? The preparation for adult life, are we allowing an interest to be followed so that they can develop their individuality. Look at our strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats (almost always about parents). Do we allow enough time for production and exchange to happen? Who decides what needs to be produced? How about the exchange process? We should look at the social organization and the different qualities of it. Is there interdependence? Where are you in terms of independence? Does community life reflect the qualities that you would like for it to have: friendships, helpfulness, collaboration. Are there changes in the framework that the adults need to tweak, or add limits to? We look at the work that we are able to provide. Are we able to provide real work? Another strength can be that one has a dedicated team of adults and administration.

Threats

We need to know where we are so that we can make choices. Money can be a threat for some schools. That there is not enough money to create this environment (land). A threat can be political decisions that are made that you have to abide by. Or colleagues that are really good, but they leave for some reason or another. A threat is that we won't last because it is not a 9 to 5 job. So one has to know how to find rest, so that life is interesting and diverse. It's not only that you are physically working, but you are always thinking about the students...etc. Sometimes staff leave because they need to move on, and then this takes the community time to acclimate. How can we improve? What opportunities do we have? Celebrate the small wins, and then see what else can we do to improve the prepared environment? To build a community you first must have the knowledge and skills of Montessori theory, a will to act on those skills, the resources to do so, and then a determined process with actionable steps.

Vision Statement Writing for An Adolescent Community:

Each community should write a vision statement together. What is our main goal here? What is important to us? How do we move forward?

A **vision statement** looks forward and creates a mental image of the ideal state that the community wishes to achieve. It should inspire group members and should express the aspirations of the group. It should also challenge group members to work toward a better state of affairs. Questions to consider when drafting vision statements might include:

- ❖ What community problems are we seeking to solve?
- ❖ Where are we headed? What are our goals?
- ❖ If we achieved all our goals, what would we look like?

My ideal vision statement:

- ❖ What community problems are we seeking to solve?
 - Help adolescents develop optimally
 - Spiritual, intellectual, moral development
- ❖ Where are we headed? What are our goals?
 - Provide opportunities for the construction of the personality
 - Strong moral
 - Independence, choice, responsibility
 - Interdependence
- ❖ If we achieved all our goals, what would we look like?
 - Harmonious
 - Normalized
 - Curious
 - Spontaneous

This Montessori Adolescent *Center for Work and Study* is a creative and nurturing environment where adolescents live, work, and explore together in order to construct their authentic selves, and cultivate an appreciation for the earth and all beings.

Living together on this peaceful farmland, *with an emphasis on responsibility, interdependence, and meaningful work*, the adolescents are supported in their moral, spiritual, and intellectual development.

Through respect and encouragement of these young people, we hope to take one step closer towards *universal love and human solidarity*.